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1 Thessalonians

1 Thessalonians 1:1

Section 1:1: Paul greeted the believers in the town of Thessalonica

1:1a

Paul, Silvanus, and Timothy,

- ¶ It is I, Paul, with Silas and Timothy, who greet you
- ¶ I, Paul, together with Silas and Timothy greet you
- ¶ This letter is from me, Paul. Silas and Timothy join me in greeting you

Paul, Silvanus, and Timothy: Paul was the author of the letter, but he added the names of Silvanus and Timothy because they had been with him when he went to Thessalonica. They also greeted the Thessalonians.

Silvanus: Like Paul himself, Silvanus had two names: Silvanus and Silas. Silas was his Hebrew name. Silvanus was probably the Latin form of Silas. The original Greek text used the Latin form “Silvanus” at the beginning of 1 and 2 Thessalonians and 1 Peter (see RSV). However, Luke used “Silas” when he wrote about him in Acts. The important thing when you are translating these passages is to make sure that your readers know that Silvanus and Silas were the same person. Many modern English versions do this by only using the name “Silas” in the text (as NIV and GNT have done) and having a footnote to say that the Greek text has Silvanus. Another possibility would be to use Silvanus in your translation and use a footnote to explain that he was the same person as Silas of Acts.

1:1b

To the church of the Thessalonians

- who belong to the group of believers who meet together in the town of Thessalonica.
- who are believers in the town of Thessalonica,

To the church of the Thessalonians: There is no verb in the Greek text of this verse. You may need to include a verb such as “write” to make this phrase more natural in your language, for example,

I, Paul, along with Timothy and Silas write to the church of the Thessalonians....

the church: The Greek word *ekklēsia*, which is often translated as church, never refers to a building but rather to a group of Christians who regularly met to-

gether to worship God and the Lord Jesus Christ. Also see the word “church”, sense 2 in KBT.

the Thessalonians: The people to whom Paul was writing lived in the town called Thessalonica. Thessalonica had a population of about 200,000 people. This was considered a large town or city at that time in history.

1:1c

in God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ:

- Those are united to God who is the Father and to the Lord Jesus Christ.
- and who belong to God our^(incl) Father and to our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ.

in: The word in is one of the most difficult words to translate accurately and naturally when it relates to a person (for example, in God) because its meaning depends on the context. Here it means “those who have a special relationship with God and the Lord Jesus Christ,” “those who are united with God and the Lord Jesus Christ” (GW), “those who belong to God and the Lord Jesus Christ” (GNT, NLT, REB).

God the Father: In some languages it is not possible to just say “the father.” Instead, it is necessary to specify whose father is being talked about. For example:

our^(incl) father

his father

the Lord: This is translated from the Greek word *kurios*, which means “master,” “chief,” or “leader.” It is a title that indicates respect and has a positive meaning. In the New Testament, the Greek word *kurios* nearly always refers to Christ. Occasionally it refers to God or a human being. In some languages, you can not say “the Lord” or “the master,” and so it may be necessary to say “our Lord” or “my Lord.” See the note on “Father” immediately before this one. If this applies to your language, you should use the possessive pronoun “our (incl).”

Jesus Christ: In this letter, as in most letters in the New Testament, Christ is not used as a title. Rather, it had become a proper name. It is often coupled with Jesus: Jesus Christ or Christ Jesus. You should transliterate these words, Jesus Christ, in this letter, as do almost all English translations. See Christ, sense 1b in KBT for further advice.

1:1d

Grace and peace to you.

- May God act graciously toward you and cause you to be at peace.
- We^(excl) pray that God will bless you and cause you to be at peace.

Grace and peace to you: This is a typical greeting. Both Paul and Peter used it in their letters.

Grace: Here Grace refers to the way that God blesses people both materially and spiritually. See grace, sense A1 in KBT.

peace: Here peace refers to people being physically, mentally, and spiritually well in all circumstances, even when they have troubles and difficult circumstances.

you: Throughout the whole letter of 1 Thessalonians the word you is plural.

This expression is really a prayer. The second Meaning Line in the Display shows how to express this aspect explicitly. See also the note on 5:23a.

1 Thessalonians 1:2

Section 1:2–10: Paul thanked God for the way that the Thessalonians had believed the gospel and continued to obey God

Paragraph 1:2–3

Whenever Paul prayed for the Thessalonians, he thanked God for them because he remembered the way that they had trusted God, the way that they loved others, and the way that they confidently expected that the Lord Jesus would return.

1:2

We always thank God for all of you, remembering you in our prayers

- ¶ Every time we^(excl) pray to God for you, we^(excl) continually/unceasingly thank God for you all.

We always thank God for all of you, remembering you in our prayers: Paul wrote similar statements in 2 Thessalonians 1:3a and Philippians 1:3–5.

We: This refers to Paul and his companions.

1 Thessalonians 1:3

Section 1:2–10: Paul thanked God for the way that the Thessalonians had believed the gospel and continued to obey God

Paragraph 1:2–3

Whenever Paul prayed for the Thessalonians, he thanked God for them because he remembered the way that they had trusted God, the way that they loved

others, and the way that they confidently expected that the Lord Jesus would return.

1:3a

and continually recalling before our God and Father

- When we^(excl) pray to God our^(incl) Father we^(excl) always remember the following three things:

and continually recalling before our God and Father: Of course, neither Paul nor God had forgotten the Thessalonians or what they had done. Rather, this phrase means that as Paul prayed for them, he remembered certain things about them (1:3b–d).

continually: The Greek word *adialeiptōs*, which the BSB translates as continually, actually occurs at the end of 1:2 in the Greek text. However, the commentators do not agree about which verb this word modifies. There are two possibilities:

1. It modifies *mnēmoneuō* “recall” in 1:3a. (BSB, NIV, KJV, GW, JB, NASB, NCV, NRSV, REB, SSA)
2. It modifies the Greek phrase *mneian poioumenoi* “making mention” in 1:2. (GNT, RSV, CEV, NEB, NET, NJB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1) because it is the most natural way to understand the Greek (see SSA, pages 22–23 for more details of why this is recommended).

before: This word is used in a figurative way here. Paul was saying that when he prayed to God, it was as if he was in the presence of a king to request something. You should translate this carefully so your readers do not misunderstand and think that Paul was talking about going to a specific place to pray.

our God and Father: In some languages using a possessive such as “our” with God might imply that God was in some sense possessed or owned. Clearly this phrase does not mean that here, because God cannot be owned by anyone. In other languages using a possessive might mean that Paul’s God was only one God among many. This is also not true, because Paul’s God is the only God. Here the expression our God means “the God whom we worship/serve.” Another method of avoiding the problem in this context is to combine the expression our God with and Father and say: “God who is our (incl) Father.”

1:3b–d

your work of faith, your labor of love, and your enduring hope in our Lord Jesus Christ: In this part of the verse Paul listed the three aspects of the Thessalonians’ behavior that he remembered before God when he thanked God for them. The Greek here literally says: “...of you the work of the faith and labor of

the love and endurance of the hope...” The following notes discuss the connection between faith and work, love and labor, hope and endurance.

your: In Greek the word *humōn* “of you (plur), your (plur)” only occurs once at the beginning of the list, but it belongs with all three phrases, as the BSB shows.

1:3b

your work of faith,

- the way you work for God because you believe in the Lord Jesus,

your work of faith: Literally “of you the work of the faith.” Commentators suggest two meanings for this expression:

1. Their work was the result of their faith. This means that they worked because they believed in Jesus. (GNT, NIV, NCV, SSA).
2. Their work proved they had faith. (REB, JB)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1) because it has the strongest commentary support.

1:3c

your labor of love,

- and the way you work to help other believers because you love them,
- and the way that you love others which makes you work hard to help them,

your labor of love: Literally “of you...the labor of the love.” Most scholars think that this means that because the Thessalonians loved other believers, they worked diligently to help them. When you translate this, it may be necessary to make clear who loves and who is the one loved. One way to do this would be:

You work diligently to help other believers, because you love them.

1:3d

and your enduring hope in our Lord Jesus Christ.

- and that because you are certain that our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ will come again you endure persecution.
- and how the fact that you are looking forward to the return of our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ causes you to continue believing firmly despite being persecuted.

and your enduring hope in our Lord Jesus Christ: Literally “of you...the endurance of the hope of our Lord Jesus Christ.”

enduring hope: Literally “endurance of hope.” Biblical scholars understand this expression in one of two ways:

1. It means that the Thessalonians endured persecution because they believed strongly in the Lord Jesus. In other words, what they believed caused them to endure. (NIV, NCV, SSA)
2. It means that their hope was steadfast, that it endured. For example:

how your hope in our Lord Jesus Christ is firm (GNT) (BSB, GNT, GW, CEV, NJB).

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1). 1 Thessalonians 1:6, 2:14, 3:4, and 3:8 support this. In these verses Paul spoke favorably about how the Christians had endured firmly while people were persecuting them.

hope in our Lord Jesus Christ: In this context, the event that the Thessalonians were hoping for was the time when the Lord Jesus would return. See 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18.

hope: In English a person can “hope” that something will happen without being sure in any way that it will happen. However, in the biblical sense it means “being certain that something will happen.” It is almost equivalent to “strongly believing that something will happen.”

1 Thessalonians 1:4

Section 1:2–10: Paul thanked God for the way that the Thessalonians had believed the gospel and continued to obey God

Paragraph 1:4–10

Paul knew that the Thessalonians to whom he wrote were people whom God had chosen to be his own people. He knew this because he saw how they had responded when he and his companions preached the gospel to them. The Thessalonians not only observed that Paul and his companions believed what they preached. They also saw that the Holy Spirit confirmed that what they said was true. The result was that some of the Thessalonians believed in Jesus, even though fellow citizens persecuted them. Other believers in the regions of Macedonia and Achaia heard about how the Thessalonians had believed the gospel. Therefore, the Thessalonians had become an example to many people in different places. The result was that wherever Paul and his companions went to preach, the people there had already heard how the Thessalonians had become believers in Christ.

1:4

Brothers who are beloved by God, we know that He has chosen you,

- ¶ Brothers whom God loves, we^(excl) thank God also because we^(excl) know that he has chosen you to be his own people.

Brothers who are beloved by God: This is an example of a vocative phrase, that is, a term of direct address to someone. In some languages, vocative phrases come at the beginning of a sentence; in other languages, they can occur elsewhere in the sentence. You should put this in the natural position in the sentence for your language.

Brothers: This term was frequently used in the New Testament to refer to fellow Christians. It shows that Christians are like brothers and sisters in God's family. It is better to use a general term that includes both elder and younger siblings, male and female, if you can, rather than a more specific term. In some languages, as is the case with the word "father" (see the note on "God the Father" in 1:1c), when the word "brother" is used, it is necessary to specify whose brother is being talked about. If this is true in your language, you should use "our (excl)."

we know: The Greek word that the BSB translates as we know is more literally "knowing." It connects back to 1:2. The connection between 1:2 and 1:4 is: "we thank God...because we know..." See the Display on 1:4. The fact that God had chosen the Thessalonians to become his people was yet another reason why Paul thanked God for them.

that He has chosen you: God chooses people for many different purposes. Passages in the New Testament tend to focus on one of these purposes rather than including them all. Some of the purposes are:

1. God chooses to save people,
2. he chooses them to be his own people,
3. he chooses them to receive eternal life,
4. he chooses them to be believers,
5. he chooses them to serve him,
6. he chooses them to be like Christ.

Paul did not make it clear which of these he meant in this passage. Different commentators suggest all the examples above as possibilities. The option that God has chosen the Thessalonians to be his people seems to include the other options and matches the Old Testament idea of God choosing the Israelites to be his special people. So it is recommended that you follow this if you need to make this clear in your translation.

1 Thessalonians 1:5

Section 1:2–10: Paul thanked God for the way that the Thessalonians had believed the gospel and continued to obey God

Paragraph 1:4–10

Paul knew that the Thessalonians to whom he wrote were people whom God had chosen to be his own people. He knew this because he saw how they had responded when he and his companions preached the gospel to them. The Thessalonians not only observed that Paul and his companions believed what they preached. They also saw that the Holy Spirit confirmed that what they said was true. The result was that some of the Thessalonians believed in Jesus, even though fellow citizens persecuted them. Other believers in the regions of Macedonia and Achaia heard about how the Thessalonians had believed the gospel. Therefore, the Thessalonians had become an example to many people in different places. The result was that wherever Paul and his companions went to preach, the people there had already heard how the Thessalonians had become believers in Christ.

1:5a

because our gospel came to you

- We^(excl) know this because, when we^(excl) came to you and told you the good news concerning Jesus Christ,

because: Paul described in 1:5–9 the basis for what he stated in 1:4, that is, Paul and his companions knew that God had chosen the Thessalonians because of all the things he was about to list in 1:5–9.

our gospel: When Paul talked about "our gospel," he meant "the gospel that we preach." He did not mean that his gospel was different from other people's.

gospel: In the New Testament, the term gospel refers to the good news that God has made a way to save people by means of Jesus' death. See "gospel" in KBT and in the glossary.

came to you: Paul was referring to the fact that he and his companions came to Thessalonica and preached to the people there. The people to whom he was writing had heard and accepted the message that Paul preached.

1:5b

not only in word,

- it was not just the words that we^(excl) spoke to you that caused you to believe in Christ,

not only in word: This means that when Paul and his companions told the Thessalonians the good news

about Jesus, they did not only preach words to them. The singular form of word refers to words in general.

1:5c

but also in power, in the Holy Spirit,

- but it was also the Holy Spirit working powerfully in us^(excl),

but also in power: Scholars do not agree about whether this means:

1. That Paul and his companions preached powerfully,
2. That the message had a powerful effect on the Thessalonians.

Although both of these options are undoubtedly true, the context of this verse suggests that the focus is on Paul's preaching, not the response of the Thessalonians. So it is recommended that you follow the first option (1).

in the Holy Spirit: Scholars do not agree about how this phrase connects to the other phrases in this verse. There are four possibilities:

1. It connects to the phrase "with power" above. This means that Paul and his companions preached powerfully because the Holy Spirit was working in them. For example:

in the power of the Holy Spirit (REB)

1. It connects with the phrase "and with great conviction" in 1:5d. This means that it was the Holy Spirit who produced the great conviction.
2. It connects with both "with power" and "with great conviction."
3. The phrase is simply the second item in a list of three ways that the gospel came to the Thessalonians: it came (a) with power, (b) with the Holy Spirit, and (c) with deep conviction.

Most English versions are ambiguous. However, the majority of commentators support the first option (1). If you need to select one option in your translation, it is recommended that you also follow this option. Words alone would not have been enough to persuade the Thessalonians to believe in God and the Lord Jesus Christ. It required the Holy Spirit's power to persuade them.

1:5d

and with great conviction—

- and you realised that we^(excl) strongly believed the words that we^(excl) spoke were true.

and with great conviction: The Greek words that the BSB translates as great conviction can also be trans-

lated "full assurance" or "complete certainty." Biblical scholars do not agree to whom great conviction applied. There are two possibilities:

1. It applied to Paul and his companions, who were fully convinced that their message was true. (GNT, CEV, NCV, REB)
2. It applied to the Thessalonians, who were convinced that the message was true. (NJB, NLT)

It makes most sense to interpret this phrase in the same way as 1:5c. Not only did Paul and his companions preach powerfully because the Holy Spirit enabled them to do that, but also they were fully convinced that what they said was true. Therefore, it is recommended that you follow the first option (1).

1:5e

just as you know we lived among you for your sake.

- You know this since you know well how we^(excl) behaved among you for your benefit.
- You know that, when we^(excl) were living among you, we^(excl) behaved in such a way as to help you.

just as you know we lived among you: In the Greek text 1:2–5 is one long sentence. This clause (1:5e) in the Greek begins with *kathōs*, which the BSB has translated as just as. The Thessalonians had seen how Paul and his companions had behaved while they were in Thessalonica. Therefore, they knew that what Paul had just said in 1:5a–d was true. See 1 Thessalonians 2:1–12 for details about Paul's time in Thessalonica.

for your sake: That is, "for your benefit." Paul did not specify what "benefit" he meant here. So it is recommended that you use as general an expression as you can to translate this part of the verse. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in order to help you (NCV)

and how we helped you (CEV)

1 Thessalonians 1:6

Section 1:2–10: Paul thanked God for the way that the Thessalonians had believed the gospel and continued to obey God

Paragraph 1:4–10

Paul knew that the Thessalonians to whom he wrote were people whom God had chosen to be his own people. He knew this because he saw how they had responded when he and his companions preached the gospel to them. The Thessalonians not only observed that Paul and his companions believed what they

preached. They also saw that the Holy Spirit confirmed that what they said was true. The result was that some of the Thessalonians believed in Jesus, even though fellow citizens persecuted them. Other believers in the regions of Macedonia and Achaia heard about how the Thessalonians had believed the gospel. Therefore, the Thessalonians had become an example to many people in different places. The result was that wherever Paul and his companions went to preach, the people there had already heard how the Thessalonians had become believers in Christ.

1:6a

And you became imitators of us and of the Lord

- You imitated the way we^(excl) behaved and also imitated the way the Lord Jesus Christ behaved.

And you became imitators of us and of the Lord:

Like 1:5, this sentence connects to 1:4. Paul and his companions knew that God had chosen the Thessalonians not only because the gospel had come to them with power (1:5) but also because they had accepted it. Also, they became imitators of Paul and the Lord. They imitated the way that they had seen Paul behave. They also acted in the way that he had taught them that Jesus had acted. This can also be expressed:

You took us and the Lord as your model (NJB)

you followed our example and the example of the Lord (CEV)

You were like us and the Lord in the way you behaved. (UBS, page 10)

1:6b

when you welcomed the message with the joy of the Holy Spirit,

- you joyfully accepted this message because the Holy Spirit caused you to rejoice,
- the Holy Spirit caused you to rejoice as you believed the message which we^(excl) preached to you,

when you welcomed the message with the joy of the Holy Spirit: Normally people are sad when they suffer. However, the Holy Spirit enabled the Thessalonians to be joyful even while they suffered. See Galatians 5:22; Romans 5:3, 5:5.

The commentators do not agree how the phrase you welcomed the message relates to the phrase in 1:6a “you became imitators of us and of the Lord.” There are two possibilities:

1. The connection is one of manner, that is, the Thessalonians imitated Paul and Jesus. Although people were persecuting them, they joyfully accepted the message. (NLT)
2. The connection is a time connection, that is, the Thessalonians began to imitate Paul and Jesus when/after they had joyfully accepted the message. Therefore, the Thessalonians imitated the whole way that Paul and Jesus behaved, not just the way that they suffered. (BSB, NET)

Most English versions are ambiguous (see the NASB). It is recommended that you follow the first option (1), as it has the best commentary support. The Thessalonians joyfully believed the gospel and they continued to be joyful even while they suffered. This is how they became like Paul and the Lord Jesus Christ.

the message: Paul used the Greek noun *logos* here, which means “message” or “word.” He was specifically referring to the message about Jesus that he had preached to them (1:5a). This word could be translated here as “gospel” (as in 1:5a) or “the message about Jesus.” The important thing is to make clear that Paul was referring to the same message here and in 1:5a.

1:6c

in spite of your great suffering.

- although some people caused you to suffer greatly when you believed the message that we^(excl) preached.

in spite of your great suffering: People were persecuting the believers severely because they believed in Christ and in what he had taught. However, although this happened, other Thessalonians became believers.

1 Thessalonians 1:7

Section 1:2–10: Paul thanked God for the way that the Thessalonians had believed the gospel and continued to obey God

Paragraph 1:4–10

Paul knew that the Thessalonians to whom he wrote were people whom God had chosen to be his own people. He knew this because he saw how they had responded when he and his companions preached the gospel to them. The Thessalonians not only observed that Paul and his companions believed what they preached. They also saw that the Holy Spirit confirmed that what they said was true. The result was that some of the Thessalonians believed in Jesus, even though fellow citizens persecuted them. Other believers in the regions of Macedonia and Achaia heard about how the Thessalonians had believed the gospel. Therefore, the Thessalonians had become an example to many people.

ple in different places. The result was that wherever Paul and his companions went to preach, the people there had already heard how the Thessalonians had become believers in Christ.

1:7

As a result, you have become an example to all the believers in Macedonia and Achaia.

- Because of this, all those who believe in the Lord Jesus in the other parts of Macedonia and in Achaia considered you as people they should imitate.

As a result, you have become an example: The Thessalonians believers imitated how Paul and the Lord Jesus behaved (1:6a). The result was that they were an example for other believers to follow.

in Macedonia and Achaia: Thessalonica was in the province or region of Macedonia, the northern part of Greece. Be careful that your translation does not cause people to think that Thessalonica was not in Macedonia. If this is a problem, you could say “in the other parts of Macedonia” rather than in Macedonia. Achaia was the southern part of Greece. See the Introduction for more details about the geographical and political situation.

1 Thessalonians 1:8

Section 1:2–10: Paul thanked God for the way that the Thessalonians had believed the gospel and continued to obey God

Paragraph 1:4–10

Paul knew that the Thessalonians to whom he wrote were people whom God had chosen to be his own people. He knew this because he saw how they had responded when he and his companions preached the gospel to them. The Thessalonians not only observed that Paul and his companions believed what they preached. They also saw that the Holy Spirit confirmed that what they said was true. The result was that some of the Thessalonians believed in Jesus, even though fellow citizens persecuted them. Other believers in the regions of Macedonia and Achaia heard about how the Thessalonians had believed the gospel. Therefore, the Thessalonians had become an example to many people in different places. The result was that wherever Paul and his companions went to preach, the people there had already heard how the Thessalonians had become believers in Christ.

1:8a

For not only did the message of the Lord ring out from you

- Just as the sound of a trumpet is heard all around, so the message about the Lord Jesus has spread from you not only
- It was because of you that people of the surrounding area heard the message about the Lord Jesus Christ. And it was not only

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For connects back to 1:7. In 1:7, Paul explained that the Thessalonians had become a model for other believers. In this verse he explained how that happened. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. Connect this verse to 1:7 in a natural way in your language.

did the message of the Lord ring out from you: Paul used a metaphor here. When someone blows a trumpet or a horn the sound of the instrument spreads out from that place. In a similar way, the Lord’s message had spread out from the Thessalonians to the rest of Greece and beyond.

the message of the Lord: In this context this probably refers to the gospel. Here is another way to translate this:

the message about the Lord (GNT)

The text does not tell us how the gospel went forth from the Thessalonians. They themselves may have sent out missionaries to other towns. Alternatively, travelers and traders may have told people in other places about how the Thessalonian Christians believed in God and how they behaved.

1:8b

to Macedonia and Achaia,

- to the people who live throughout the regions of Macedonia and Achaia.
- the people who live in the regions of Macedonia and Achaia who heard it,

1:8c

but your faith in God has gone out to every place,

- Rather, news about how you trust in God has reached everywhere.
- but people everywhere we^(excl) go have heard how you trust in God.

every place: This is hyperbole, that is, exaggerated language to emphasize something. It means “many places.” If you cannot use hyperbole in your language, you can clarify it in one of the following ways:

- With a specific statement that means “everywhere that Paul visited.”

- With a general statement, for example “many places.” Most commentators support this view.

Either of these is acceptable. The Display follows the first.

1:8d

so that we have no need to say anything more.

- So we^(excl) do not need to tell anyone about this.

so that we have no need to say anything more: This does not mean that Paul and his companions did not need to preach the gospel anymore. It means that they did not need to tell people how the Thessalonians had believed in God.

anything more: Here Paul implies that he does not need to say anything more about what he had just been talking about in 1:8c, the Thessalonians’ faith in God.

1 Thessalonians 1:9

Section 1:2–10: Paul thanked God for the way that the Thessalonians had believed the gospel and continued to obey God

Paragraph 1:4–10

Paul knew that the Thessalonians to whom he wrote were people whom God had chosen to be his own people. He knew this because he saw how they had responded when he and his companions preached the gospel to them. The Thessalonians not only observed that Paul and his companions believed what they preached. They also saw that the Holy Spirit confirmed that what they said was true. The result was that some of the Thessalonians believed in Jesus, even though fellow citizens persecuted them. Other believers in the regions of Macedonia and Achaia heard about how the Thessalonians had believed the gospel. Therefore, the Thessalonians had become an example to many people in different places. The result was that wherever Paul and his companions went to preach, the people there had already heard how the Thessalonians had become believers in Christ.

1:9a

For they themselves report what kind of welcome you gave us,

- Instead, everywhere we^(excl) go the people are talking about what happened when we^(excl) visited you.
- We^(excl) don’t need to tell anyone because everywhere we^(excl) go people discussing the way we started our work among you.

For: This gives the reason why Paul and his companions did not need to tell people about the Thessalo-

nians’ faith (1:8d): It was because people already knew about that wherever he went.

they themselves: This refers to the people of Macedonia, Achaia, and the “every place” of 1:8c.

report: The Greek verb *apaggellō*, which the BSB translates as report, here means “to tell.” These people told everyone they met. Therefore, Paul and his companions did not need to say anything (1:8d).

what kind of welcome you gave us: The Greek word *eisodos*, which the BSB translates as welcome, literally means “entrance.” The commentators do not agree how this word should be understood here. There are two possibilities:

1. It should be understood literally. This focuses on Paul and his companions and what they did in Thessalonica. For example:

our visit to you (REB)

how we started the work among you” (NJB) (REB, NJB)

1. It should be understood figuratively. It means “welcome.” This focuses on the way that the Thessalonians welcomed Paul and his companions and accepted their message. (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, CEV, GW, NCV, NLT)

Although most English versions prefer the second option, it is recommended that you follow the first option (1). Most commentators support this option. The whole passage focuses on the successful nature of Paul’s ministry. This makes the first option more likely. In addition, 2:1 uses the same Greek word with this meaning.

1:9b

and how you turned to God from idols to serve the living and true God

- They tell everyone how you stopped worshipping your gods which are not alive and you began to worship the only real God who is alive.

and how you turned to God from idols: This refers to how the Thessalonians stopped worshipping their traditional gods and idols and began worshipping God. At this time in history, the expression “to turn to God from idols” usually described people who had stopped worshipping idols and had become Jews. But here Paul was referring to people that had become Christians not Jews. The words in 1:10 make this clear. So it seems that Paul was saying that the majority of the

Thessalonian Christians had changed directly from their traditional religion to Christianity. They did not first convert to the Jewish religion, as some of those in Acts 17:4 did.

idols: When Paul talked about idols, he was referring both to the spirit and the object or image that represents it. Therefore, you can translate idols by the word or phrase that your language uses to refer to traditional fetishes, gods, or spirits. However, if possible, use a general word that refers to any idol, not the name of a specific one.

to serve: The Greek word *douleuō* used here means “to serve a master.” However, Paul did not mean working for God. He meant becoming wholeheartedly committed to God, acknowledging him as Lord and worshiping him.

the living and true God: The expression the living... God is frequently found in the Old Testament, for example, Psalm 42:2. It means “the only God who is alive.” The expression “the true God...the living God” is found in Jeremiah 10:10. It emphasizes that there is only one God, a living one, and all other so-called gods are false. Paul used that meaning here. Paul was praising the Thessalonians because they had stopped worshiping their dead, false idols and now worshiped the God who is alive and is the only real God.

1 Thessalonians 1:10

Section 1:2–10: Paul thanked God for the way that the Thessalonians had believed the gospel and continued to obey God

Paragraph 1:4–10

Paul knew that the Thessalonians to whom he wrote were people whom God had chosen to be his own people. He knew this because he saw how they had responded when he and his companions preached the gospel to them. The Thessalonians not only observed that Paul and his companions believed what they preached. They also saw that the Holy Spirit confirmed that what they said was true. The result was that some of the Thessalonians believed in Jesus, even though fellow citizens persecuted them. Other believers in the regions of Macedonia and Achaia heard about how the Thessalonians had believed the gospel. Therefore, the Thessalonians had become an example to many people in different places. The result was that wherever Paul and his companions went to preach, the people there had already heard how the Thessalonians had become believers in Christ.

1:10a

and to await His Son from heaven,

- And they tell everyone how you now look forward to the time when God’s Son will come from heaven,
- And they tell everyone how you are waiting expectantly for God’s Son to return to earth from heaven.

and to await His Son from heaven: This refers to the time when Jesus will return to earth. This is a theme in Paul’s letters to the Thessalonians. See 1 Thessalonians 3:13, 4:13–18, 5:1–3, and 2 Thessalonians 2:1–12 for further explanation.

to await: In this context this expression implies “expecting with certainty that Jesus will return.” Here is another way to translate this expression:

to wait expectantly (REB)

His Son: The phrase His Son refers to God’s Son, Jesus. “The Son of God” or “God’s Son” is a title that was often used to refer to a savior who would be a descendant of King David. God would send this savior to rescue his people. This person was often referred to as the “Messiah” or “Christ.”

The title “the Son of God” also indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. The relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. But God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. The Son of God existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

In areas where people do not understand the title “the Son of God” in this way, you may want to include a footnote that explains the correct meaning. Here is a suggested footnote:

The title “his Son” or “the Son of God” refers to Jesus. It indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It does not mean that God the Father had a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. Mary became pregnant with Jesus in a miraculous way by the Holy Spirit of God.

In some languages, it is natural to speak of a son as a “child,” without specifying male or female. If that is true in your language, you may use a more general term, such as:

his Child
A translation of the title “the Son of God” must include a familial term such as “son”

or “child.” Translations such as “the man who is God,” “the divine man,” or “the God man” are not acceptable, since they do not retain familial language. Examples of acceptable translation options include “the Son who comes from God” and “the divine/unique/eternal Son of God.”

Other verses will usually make clear that Jesus was a male child. If you use a phrase such as “his male child,” be sure that it does not imply that God had another child who was female.

heaven: The word heaven refers to the place where God lives. Many languages use the same term for “sky” and for heaven.

1:10b

whom He raised from the dead—Jesus

- It is this same Jesus whom God raised from death,

1:10c

our deliverer from the coming wrath.

- and he delivers us^(incl) from God’s anger that will punish those who sin.
- and it is he who keeps us^(incl) safe so that God will not punish us^(incl) when he punishes those who have not believed in his Son.

our deliverer: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deliverer is a present participle in Greek and therefore includes both the present and the future. Jesus is delivering his people now and he will deliver them in the future so that God will not punish them on the day when he judges all people.

from the coming wrath: This refers to God’s anger. Because God is holy, he is angry when people sin. Paul referred to this anger as coming because he was referring to the day when God will judge everyone. On that day God will show this anger and he will punish people who have sinned but have never repented and trusted in Jesus.

1 Thessalonians 2:1

Section 2:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians about his visit to them

Paragraph 2:1–2

Paul reminded the Thessalonians about how he and his companions came to Thessalonica. Although people had persecuted them in Philippi and forced them to leave, God had helped them to have the courage to continue their journey to Thessalonica and preach the gospel there.

2:1

You yourselves know, brothers, that our visit to you was not in vain.

- ¶ You yourselves know, brothers, that when we^(excl) visited you in Thessalonica it was not a waste of time.
- ¶ My kin, you yourselves know that when we^(excl) visited you it definitely produced good results.
- ¶ You yourselves know, fellow believers, that when we^(excl) visited you in Thessalonica we^(excl) did not fail to see many people believe in the Lord Jesus.

You yourselves know: In Greek, the word that the BSB translates as You yourselves is emphatic. The word You contrasts with “they themselves” in 1:9a. Not only were other people talking about Paul’s visit to Thessalonica, but the Thessalonians themselves knew what had happened.

brothers: See the note on 1:4.

our visit to you: The Greek word eisodos, which the BSB translates as visit here, is the same word that it translated as “welcome” in 1:9a. It is most logical to translate the word the same way in both places. Nearly all commentators and English versions agree that here it means visit.

was not in vain: Rather than simply saying “our visit to you was a success,” Paul chose to make his statement stronger by using two negatives: not and in vain. This sort of figure of speech is called “litotes.” Paul wanted to emphasize that his visit had definitely had a good result. When he had preached the gospel, it had resulted in the Thessalonians believing in Jesus Christ. Paul was referring to 1:9, which says that many Thessalonians had stopped worshiping idols and had begun to serve God.

If you do not use litotes in your language to strengthen a statement, you may need to restate this part of the verse positively. For example:

You know, brothers, that our visit to you was a great success.

You know, brothers, that when we visited you, there were great results.

1 Thessalonians 2:2

Section 2:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians about his visit to them

Paragraph 2:1–2

Paul reminded the Thessalonians about how he and his companions came to Thessalonica. Although people had persecuted them in Philippi and forced them to leave, God had helped them to have the courage to continue their journey to Thessalonica and preach the gospel there.

2:2a

As you are aware, we had already endured suffering and shameful treatment in Philippi.

- On the contrary, as you know, although the people in the town of Philippi had persecuted us^(excl) and insulted us^(excl) before we^(excl) came to you at Thessalonica,
- Indeed, as you know well, even though before we^(excl) came to you at Thessalonica, we^(excl) had been persecuted and insulted in Philippi,

In the Greek text, the conjunction *alla* (“but”) actually occurs at the beginning of the verse. Versions such as the ESV, NASB, and NET place it there. This makes it clear that what Paul was about to say in 2:2 connects to 2:1. Paul was saying that his visit had not been a failure but, on the contrary, it had been a success because, despite persecution, he had still preached in Thessalonica. However, other versions, including the BSB and the CEV, NIV, and NLT, place this conjunction before 2:2b-c. This indicates the contrast between Paul’s boldness and the persecution that could have made him afraid. Place this conjunction where it would be natural in your language.

If you translated 2:1 using litotes, you could use an expression such as “on the contrary” here. If, however, you used a positive statement, you will need to use a word such as “indeed” to link the two verses.

As you are aware, we had already endured suffering and shameful treatment in Philippi: See Acts 16:16–40 for details of Paul’s suffering at Philippi.

2:2b

But in the face of strong opposition,

- yet in spite of that, even though many people opposed us,^(excl)

in the face of strong opposition: The Greek is literally “in much struggle.” Most commentators and versions agree that Paul was referring to the people who had opposed him and tried to stop him preaching everywhere he went.

2:2c

we were bold in our God to speak to you the gospel of God.

- our^(incl) God helped us^(excl) to have the courage to come/go to Thessalonica and tell you the gospel that he gave us^(excl).

we were bold in our God to speak to you: It was God who had enabled Paul and his companions to preach boldly in Thessalonica, even after they had been persecuted in Philippi.

our God: In some languages, using a possessive such as “our” with God might imply that God was in some sense possessed or owned. Clearly this is not the meaning here, since God cannot be owned by anyone. In other languages it might mean that Paul’s God was only one God among many. This is also not true, because Paul’s God is the only God. The meaning is “God whom we worship/serve.”

the gospel of God: God is the source of the good news concerning Jesus Christ. So you could translate the phrase the gospel of God as “the good news that God gave” or “the good news that came from God.”

1 Thessalonians 2:3

Section 2:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians about his visit to them

Paragraph 2:3–9

Paul then defended himself and his companions against the accusations that he believed that people were making. He affirmed that what he and his companions had preached was true and that they wanted to please God rather than people. Paul and his companions had never asked anyone to honor them personally, although they could have done that because they were apostles. In the Greek world there were many people who traveled from place to place teaching people and living at the expense of those who began to follow them. Paul wanted to emphasize how different he and his companions were from people like that. This is probably the reason why he defended himself here.

To prove this, Paul reminded the Thessalonians believers how he and his companions had worked to earn their own money so they would not burden them. He also reminded them that he and his companions behaved toward them the way a good father behaves toward his children. He then urged them to behave in a way that would please God.

In 2:3–4 Paul was describing his ministry among people in general, wherever he and his companions went

and preached. Then in 2:5 he talks about his specific ministry among the Thessalonians.

2:3a

For our appeal

- ¶ The reason that our^(excl) message to you succeeded was that when we^(excl) urge people to believe the gospel,

For: Paul and his companions had succeeded in producing the result that they had hoped to produce by preaching to the Thessalonians. That result was that Thessalonians had believed in Jesus. Here Paul gave another reason why their preaching was successful (2:1) and why they could preach the gospel boldly (2:2c).

our appeal: It is not clear from the Greek text or from most English versions to whom Paul made this appeal. There are two possibilities:

1. He appealed to people in general. (NET, SSA)
2. He appealed to the Thessalonians in particular. (GNT, CEV, GW, NJB)

If possible you should leave your translation ambiguous here. However, if you must say to whom Paul appealed, it is recommended that you follow the first option and use a word for people in general. This option has the support of most commentators.

appeal: Paul's appeal was to urge people to believe the gospel.

2:3b

does not arise from deceit or ulterior motives

- what we^(excl) say is not based on incorrect thinking, nor do we^(excl) intend to do what is morally wrong,

does not arise from: There is no verb in the Greek text in this part of the verse, yet all English translations need to supply one. Most English versions supply a verb such as “spring from,” “come from,” or “is based on.” You should choose a verb that makes it clear that Paul was saying that his appeal did not originate from error.

All English versions except the KJV supply a verb in the present tense to indicate that Paul was talking about something he did habitually. It is recommended that you use a verb tense or aspect that refers to habitual actions, that is, actions that occur frequently. This matches the tense of the verb “speak” in 2:4a, which also shows habitual action.

deceit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deceit is more literally “error” or “delusion.” This Greek word can have two meanings:

1. Paul meant that he was not mistaken or deluded or mad. (NIV, NJB, REB)
2. Paul meant that he was not deliberately deceiving them. (BSB, GW, KJV, NCV, NLT, NRSV)

Some English versions are ambiguous. Probably the first opinion (1) is correct here. Otherwise the meaning would be almost the same as 2:3c and Paul would just have been repeating himself.

ulterior motives: The Greek word *akatharsia*, which the BSB translates as ulterior motives, literally means “uncleanness.” This could mean one of two things:

1. It means any kind of moral impurity, for example, greed, ambition, vanity, pride, or sexual immorality. Preaching to gain money, as some people were doing, is one example of an “impure motive” in this context. (GW, NCV)
2. It specifically means sexual immorality. (JB)

Most English versions are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow the first meaning (1) here. Choose a general term, because most commentators agree that in this context the meaning should not be limited to sexual immorality.

2:3c

or trickery.

- and we^(excl) are not trying to deceive anyone.

or trickery: Literally, “nor trickery.” Paul was speaking generally here, so it is most likely that Paul was saying that he and his companions were not intending to deceive anyone at any time. Here are some other ways to translate this:

we didn't try to fool or trick anyone (CEV)

nor do we try to trick anyone (GNT)

He said more about this in 2:5a and 2:5b when he talked about “flattery” and “any pretext for greed.” See the notes on those verses.

1 Thessalonians 2:4

Section 2:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians about his visit to them

Paragraph 2:3–9

Paul then defended himself and his companions against the accusations that he believed that people were making. He affirmed that what he and his companions had preached was true and that they wanted to please God rather than people. Paul and his companions had never asked anyone to honor

them personally, although they could have done that because they were apostles. In the Greek world there were many people who traveled from place to place teaching people and living at the expense of those who began to follow them. Paul wanted to emphasize how different he and his companions were from people like that. This is probably the reason why he defended himself here.

To prove this, Paul reminded the Thessalonians believers how he and his companions had worked to earn their own money so they would not burden them. He also reminded them that he and his companions behaved toward them the way a good father behaves toward his children. He then urged them to behave in a way that would please God.

In 2:3–4 Paul was describing his ministry among people in general, wherever he and his companions went and preached. Then in 2:5 he talks about his specific ministry among the Thessalonians.

2:4a

Instead, we speak as those approved by God to be entrusted with the gospel,

- Instead, we^(excl) always speak as men whom God has approved as people he can trust to preach the gospel faithfully.
- On the contrary, we^(excl) speak because God has examined us^(excl) and decided that he can trust us^(excl) with this gospel message.

Instead: This verse contrasts with 2:3, where Paul used negative statements. Rather than deceitful and wrong teaching (2:3), what Paul was preaching was approved by God (2:4).

we speak as those approved by God: The way that Paul and his companions preached and behaved wherever they went showed that God had examined their motives and behavior and had found that these were pure. Here is another way to translate this:

God...has judged us worthy to be entrusted (GNT)

to be entrusted with the gospel: This is closely connected with the previous phrase. God had examined Paul and his companions and judged that he could trust them to preach the gospel faithfully.

2:4b

not in order to please men but God,

- Therefore, when we^(excl) preach, we^(excl) do not try to please people, but we^(excl) try to please God,

not in order to please men but God: Whatever Paul and his companions did, they did not do it so that hu-

man beings would praise them. It was God's approval that was important to them.

men: The Greek word *anthropos*, which the BSB translates as men, is a word that means humans beings, male and female. It is not limited to males.

2:4c

who examines our hearts.

- the one who continually examines our^(excl) hearts.
- because it is God who is continually examining what we^(excl) think and feel.

who examines our hearts: Paul was using Old Testament language here to describe how God examines what people think. The Greek verb *dokimazō*, which the BSB translates as examines, is the same verb that Paul used in 2:4a (where the BSB translates it as "approved"). There is a similar idea in 2:5c, where Paul used the expression "God is our witness" in order to emphasize again that God had approved what they were doing.

hearts: People of different languages and cultures have unique ways to express what people think and how they feel. Many of these expressions refer to parts of the body as if they were the origin of these emotions. In Paul's culture, the heart was considered to be the center of the inner life, including all thoughts, emotions and motives. You need to use the equivalent natural expression in your language.

1 Thessalonians 2:5

Section 2:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians about his visit to them

Paragraph 2:3–9

Paul then defended himself and his companions against the accusations that he believed that people were making. He affirmed that what he and his companions had preached was true and that they wanted to please God rather than people. Paul and his companions had never asked anyone to honor them personally, although they could have done that because they were apostles. In the Greek world there were many people who traveled from place to place teaching people and living at the expense of those who began to follow them. Paul wanted to emphasize how different he and his companions were from people like that. This is probably the reason why he defended himself here.

To prove this, Paul reminded the Thessalonians believers how he and his companions had worked to earn their own money so they would not burden them. He also reminded them that he and his companions

behaved toward them the way a good father behaves toward his children. He then urged them to behave in a way that would please God.

In 2:3–4 Paul was describing his ministry among people in general, wherever he and his companions went and preached. Then in 2:5 he talks about his specific ministry among the Thessalonians.

2:5c

God is our witness!

- God can testify that we^(excl) did not behave like that.

2:5

This verse is more specific than 2:3–4.

2:5a

As you know, we never used words of flattery

- You also know that when we^(excl) were with you we^(excl) never flattered you.
- You also know that when we^(excl) were with you we^(excl) did not say nice things about you just to make you happy,

As you know: The Thessalonians had observed how Paul and his companions had behaved while they were in Thessalonica. Here Paul was reminding them that because they had observed this, they knew that the things that he was going to say in the rest of the verse were true.

we never used words of flattery: Paul reminded the Thessalonians that he and his companions had never said nice things about anyone just to make them happy.

2:5b

or any pretext for greed.

- You also know that we^(excl) never did things because we^(excl) were greedy and then tried to hide that from you like someone hides his face behind a mask.
- and we^(excl) did not behave the way we^(excl) did simply to hide our^(excl) greed because we^(excl) were not greedy at all.

or any pretext for greed: The Greek word *prophasis*, which the BSB translates as pretext, in this context means “pretense” or “disguise.” Paul was reminding the Thessalonians that he and his companions were not greedy for money at all, unlike some people who were greedy for money but tried to hide it. Your language may have an idiom to express this idea. For example:

nor did we put on a mask to cover up greed (NIV)

1 Thessalonians 2:6

Section 2:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians about his visit to them

Paragraph 2:3–9

Paul then defended himself and his companions against the accusations that he believed that people were making. He affirmed that what he and his companions had preached was true and that they wanted to please God rather than people. Paul and his companions had never asked anyone to honor them personally, although they could have done that because they were apostles. In the Greek world there were many people who traveled from place to place teaching people and living at the expense of those who began to follow them. Paul wanted to emphasize how different he and his companions were from people like that. This is probably the reason why he defended himself here.

To prove this, Paul reminded the Thessalonians believers how he and his companions had worked to earn their own money so they would not burden them. He also reminded them that he and his companions behaved toward them the way a good father behaves toward his children. He then urged them to behave in a way that would please God.

In 2:3–4 Paul was describing his ministry among people in general, wherever he and his companions went and preached. Then in 2:5 he talks about his specific ministry among the Thessalonians.

2:6a

Nor did we seek praise from you or from anyone else,

- We^(excl) were not aiming to cause you or anyone else to praise us.^(excl)
- We^(excl) were not trying to cause you or anyone else to honour us.^(excl)

Nor did we seek praise from you or from anyone else:

Paul continued to describe how he and his companions preached and behaved, and he contrasted this with the behavior of the teachers who traveled from place to place. In the Greek world, such wandering teachers flattered their hearers to get money from them and to cause their hearers to honor them.

2:6b

although as apostles of Christ we had authority to demand it.

- Since we^(excl) are apostles of Christ, we^(excl) could have made you treat us^(excl) as important people.

- Since we^(excl) are apostles of Christ, we^(excl) could have acted like men who command others but we^(excl) did not.

In some Greek manuscripts, this part of 2:6 actually begins 2:7. Many English versions also begin 2:7 here. You should follow the English or national language version that is most popular in your area.

as apostles of Christ: Paul was making it clear that he and his companions were apostles, that is, that Jesus Christ had authorized them to teach and explain what Jesus taught. See “apostle”, sense 2 in the glossary and in KBT.

we had authority to demand it: The Greek here literally says “we could have been with weight.” There are two ways in which scholars interpret this idiom:

1. It means that Paul and his companions could have said how important they were and insisted that the Thessalonians respect their authority. (BSB, NIV11, NCV, GW, SSA, NJB; possibly NET, REB)
2. It means that Paul and his companions could have used their authority as apostles to burden the Thessalonians with all sorts of demands, for example, they could have insisted that the Thessalonians give them food and lodging. This would agree with 2:9c where a related verb is used. (NIV, GNT, RSV, NLT, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1), as many commentators support it and it provides the best contrast with the next verse. Paul was saying that, instead of using their authority over the Thessalonians, he and his companions behaved gently toward them.

1 Thessalonians 2:7

Section 2:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians about his visit to them

Paragraph 2:3–9

Paul then defended himself and his companions against the accusations that he believed that people were making. He affirmed that what he and his companions had preached was true and that they wanted to please God rather than people. Paul and his companions had never asked anyone to honor them personally, although they could have done that because they were apostles. In the Greek world there were many people who traveled from place to place teaching people and living at the expense of those who began to follow them. Paul wanted to emphasize how different he and his companions were from

people like that. This is probably the reason why he defended himself here.

To prove this, Paul reminded the Thessalonians believers how he and his companions had worked to earn their own money so they would not burden them. He also reminded them that he and his companions behaved toward them the way a good father behaves toward his children. He then urged them to behave in a way that would please God.

In 2:3–4 Paul was describing his ministry among people in general, wherever he and his companions went and preached. Then in 2:5 he talks about his specific ministry among the Thessalonians.

2:7

On the contrary, we were gentle among you, like a nursing mother caring for her children.

- Instead, when we^(excl) were with you, we^(excl) treated you gently, just as a nursing mother cares for her little children.

nursing mother: The Greek word *trophos*, which the BSB (like many other English versions) translates as nursing mother, is not the normal Greek word for “mother.” It refers specifically to a woman who feeds a child from her breast. Usually this is the mother of a child, but in some cultures this can be another woman. So some English versions (KJV, RSV, and REB) use the word “nurse.” However, in modern English, this word only refers to a person who works in a hospital, which is not the meaning here. Therefore, it is recommended that you translate this word as “mother” unless you have a special term with exactly the same meaning as the Greek word.

1 Thessalonians 2:8

Section 2:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians about his visit to them

Paragraph 2:3–9

Paul then defended himself and his companions against the accusations that he believed that people were making. He affirmed that what he and his companions had preached was true and that they wanted to please God rather than people. Paul and his companions had never asked anyone to honor them personally, although they could have done that because they were apostles. In the Greek world there were many people who traveled from place to place teaching people and living at the expense of those who began to follow them. Paul wanted to emphasize how different he and his companions were from people like that. This is probably the reason why he defended himself here.

To prove this, Paul reminded the Thessalonians believers how he and his companions had worked to earn their own money so they would not burden them. He also reminded them that he and his companions behaved toward them the way a good father behaves toward his children. He then urged them to behave in a way that would please God.

In 2:3–4 Paul was describing his ministry among people in general, wherever he and his companions went and preached. Then in 2:5 he talks about his specific ministry among the Thessalonians.

2:8a

We cared so deeply

- We^(excl) loved you so much

We cared so deeply: In Greek this verse begins with the word *houtōs*, which the BSB translates as so deeply. However, this word has several meanings and scholars do not agree about its meaning here. There are two possibilities:

1. It means “so deeply” or “so much”. (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, GW, NCV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)
2. It means “therefore” and links 2:8b back to 2:7. The sentence then means that Paul and his companions cared for the Thessalonians like a mother and, therefore, because they loved them so much, they were happy to share the gospel. (KJV, RSV, SSA)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1), because it fits best into the context where Paul was expressing how much he cared about the Thessalonians. It is also supported by the majority of commentaries consulted. This is something he repeats in 2:8d.

2:8b

that we were delighted to share with you not only the gospel of God,

- that we^(excl) not only gladly wanted to tell you God’s gospel,
- that we^(excl) were delighted/pleased/happy to tell you the good news God gave us,^(excl)

we were delighted to share with you not only the gospel of God: The form of the Greek verb here indicates that Paul and his companions had continually been content/happy to share the gospel and their lives with the Thessalonians while they were staying in Thessalonica.

share with you...the gospel of God: To “share the gospel” means to preach/tell the gospel to people.

gospel of God: See the note on “gospel of God” in 2:2c. This is the same phrase in Greek.

2:8c

but our own lives as well.

- but also we^(excl) were delighted to do all we^(excl) could do to help you.

but our own lives as well: Although there is no verb in this part of the verse in the Greek text, the implied verb is the same one as in 2:8b, “to share.” However, the verb in the expression “to share our own lives” does not have the same meaning as in the expression “to share the gospel.” Paul was able to use the same verb in Greek, but you may need to use a different verb in your translation. The expression “to share our lives” means to be willing to use one’s time and energy to help others.

2:8d

That is how beloved you have become to us.

- because you had become very dear to us.^(excl)
- because we^(excl) had begun to love you very much.

That is how beloved you have become to us: Here Paul expressed a similar idea to 2:8a.

1 Thessalonians 2:9

Section 2:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians about his visit to them

Paragraph 2:3–9

Paul then defended himself and his companions against the accusations that he believed that people were making. He affirmed that what he and his companions had preached was true and that they wanted to please God rather than people. Paul and his companions had never asked anyone to honor them personally, although they could have done that because they were apostles. In the Greek world there were many people who traveled from place to place teaching people and living at the expense of those who began to follow them. Paul wanted to emphasize how different he and his companions were from people like that. This is probably the reason why he defended himself here.

To prove this, Paul reminded the Thessalonians believers how he and his companions had worked to earn their own money so they would not burden them. He also reminded them that he and his companions behaved toward them the way a good father behaves toward his children. He then urged them to behave in a way that would please God.

In 2:3–4 Paul was describing his ministry among people in general, wherever he and his companions went and preached. Then in 2:5 he talks about his specific ministry among the Thessalonians.

2:9a**Surely you recall, brothers, our labor and toil.**

- Brothers, you certainly remember how diligently we^(excl) worked while we^(excl) were in Thessalonica.
- As you will remember, my kin, we^(excl) worked very hard while we^(excl) were in Thessalonica.

In the Greek text, this sentence begins with gar (“for”). It indicates here that Paul was giving an example of what he meant in 2:6b, “although ... we had authority to demand it,” in 2:7, “we were gentle among you,” and in 2:8c, “to share with you ... our own lives.”

Surely you recall: Paul reminded the Thessalonians again that they themselves already knew what he was about to state.

brothers: See the note on 1:4.

our labor and toil: The two Greek words that Paul used here, kopos and mochthos, have very similar meanings. Paul used this repetition to emphasize his statement. If you do not have two similar words that you can use here, or if it would be unnatural for you to use such repetition, you could translate this as “we worked very diligently/hard.”

2:9b**We worked night and day**

- Indeed, we^(excl) worked night and day to get money to support ourselves^(excl)
- In fact, we^(excl) worked not only during the day but also at night to earn money to pay our^(excl) own expenses

We worked night and day: Acts 18:3–5 records that Paul’s job was to make tents to sell. He may have worked late at night after he had finished teaching and preaching to the Thessalonians. Timothy and Silas may also have worked at tent-making so that Paul would be free to preach and teach.

night and day: This does not mean that Paul and his companions worked all night and all day. Paul used this expression to emphasize the long hours he worked. One way to express this would be:

we worked not only during the day but also at night

2:9c**so that we would not be a burden to anyone**

- so that we^(excl) would not burden you
- so that we^(excl) would not require you to supply what we^(excl) needed

so that we would not be a burden to anyone: The Greek word epibareō, which the BSB translates as be a burden, is related to the word baros, “weight, importance,” in 2:6b. However, here the meaning is different and nearly all scholars agree that it refers to not being a financial burden on the Thessalonians. Paul and his companions worked to support themselves so that they could buy their own food and lodging rather than expecting anyone to provide it for them.

2:9d**while we proclaimed to you the gospel of God.**

- during the time that we^(excl) preached the good news from God to you.

the gospel of God: See the notes on “the gospel of God” in 2:2c.

1 Thessalonians 2:10**Section 2:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians about his visit to them****Paragraph 2:10–12**

Again Paul asked the Thessalonian believers to remember that he and his companions had behaved correctly when they had been with them and that also they had taught the believers how to behave in order to be worthy of sharing in God’s greatness.

2:10a**You are witnesses, and so is God,**

- ¶ You yourselves, and also God, saw and can testify about us^(excl)

You are witnesses, and so is God: Paul continued to assert that he and his companions had behaved correctly. He also reminded the Thessalonians that they had seen this and could confirm it, as could God himself.

2:10b**of how holy, righteous, and blameless our conduct was among you who believed.**

- that we^(excl) did what pleased God and we^(excl) did what was just/right while we^(excl) were with you who have believed in the Lord Jesus. Also no-one could criticise us^(excl) for how we^(excl) lived among you.

how holy, righteous, and blameless our conduct was among you who believed: This means that Paul, Silvanus and Timothy behaved towards the Thessalonians in holy, righteous and blameless ways. Their behavior was appropriate and above reproach. Here is another way to translate this verse:

You are our witnesses, and so is God, that our conduct toward you who believe was pure, right and without fault. (GNT)

holy: The Greek word *hosiōs*, which the BSB translates as holy, means, in this context, being “morally pure, without any sin.” See “holy”, sense A4 in KBT and in the glossary, meaning 2.

righteous: The Greek word *dikaiōs*, which the BSB translates as righteous, means, in this context, “up-right, just conduct.” See righteous under the entry for “just”, sense A2a in KBT and in the glossary, meaning 2.

blameless: The Greek word *amemptōs*, which the BSB translates as blameless, means “without fault,” that is, God will not accuse the blameless person of any sin.

among you who believed: Paul was probably not saying that he behaved differently with the Thessalonian believers than he did with unbelievers. He was simply referring to what the Thessalonians knew from their personal experience.

1 Thessalonians 2:11

Section 2:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians about his visit to them

Paragraph 2:10–12

Again Paul asked the Thessalonian believers to remember that he and his companions had behaved correctly when they had been with them and that also they had taught the believers how to behave in order to be worthy of sharing in God’s greatness.

2:11

For you know that we treated each of you as a father treats his own children—

- Indeed you know that we^(excl) treated each of you like a father treats his own children,

For you know: The Greek phrase which the BSB translates as For you know is literally “just as you know.” Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

As you well know... (REB)

As you know (NRSV)

Paul now gave the Thessalonians some examples of the holy, righteous, and blameless way that he and his companions had behaved when they were in Thessalonica.

we treated each of you: The words we treated are not in the Greek text in 2:11. The BSB has included these

words to make the connection with 2:10b clear. Most modern English versions add a similar verb and you will probably also need to do that.

as a father treats his own children: In 2:7, Paul had already compared himself and his companions to a mother who gently cared for her children. Here he compared himself and his companions to a father who teaches his children how to behave.

1 Thessalonians 2:12

Section 2:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians about his visit to them

Paragraph 2:10–12

Again Paul asked the Thessalonian believers to remember that he and his companions had behaved correctly when they had been with them and that also they had taught the believers how to behave in order to be worthy of sharing in God’s greatness.

2:12a

encouraging you, comforting you, and urging you to walk in a manner worthy of God,

- that is, we^(excl) continually encouraged, comforted and urged you to behave in the way that pleases God,
- that is, we^(excl) continually encouraged, comforted and insisted that you should behave in the way that pleases God,

In some Greek manuscripts this part of 2:12 is part of 2:11. Some English versions, such as the RSV, NASB, and GW, similarly include 2:12a in 2:11. You should follow the English or national language version that is most common in your area.

encouraging you, comforting you: The two Greek verbs here, *parakaleō* and *paramutheomai*, have similar meanings. They both include the meanings “to encourage, exhort, comfort.” If you have two similar words you can use here, you should do so. Otherwise, you can use a single term.

and urging you: The Greek word *marturomai*, which the BSB translates as urging, has a different meaning from the other two verbs in this part of the verse. It means “telling someone how necessary or important it is to do a particular thing.” Here is another way to translate this in English:

insist (NET)

The form of all three of these verbs in Greek (they are present participles) mean that these were actions that happened continually. Paul and his companions

continued encouraging, comforting, and urging the Thessalonians.

to walk in a manner worthy of God: This means “to behave in such a way that God would be pleased that you are members of his kingdom.” Paul uses the verb walk to describe how people behave. See also 4:1a, where the BSB translates this word as “live.”

2:12b

who calls you into His own kingdom and glory.

- the one who invites you to become part of his kingdom and share in his greatness.
- who summons you to belong to the people over whom he rules and to share in his greatness.

who calls you into His own kingdom and glory: In Greek there is a textual problem with this part of the verse. The KJV has followed the manuscripts that have a past tense verb here: “who hath called.” However, the best manuscripts have a present participle that the BSB translates with a continuous present tense who calls. It is strongly recommended that you follow these manuscripts. All other English versions also use a present tense here.

This form of the verb literally means “the one calling, the caller.” Paul used this verb form to focus on one of two things:

1. It focuses on the fact that God is the one who calls people into his kingdom. The verb then does not have any particular time/tense. God calls new people every day.
2. It focuses on God continuously calling the Thessalonians. He called them originally when they became Christians but went on calling them every day to new aspects of their Christian life.

It is not possible to know which of these aspects Paul was concentrating on here. In your translation you have two options:

- Use a continuous present tense, as most English versions have done: “who calls you.”
- In some languages it may be possible to use a nominal form: “the caller of you.”

calls you into: In some languages it may not be possible to say “call into something.” The UBS handbook suggests a verb such as “invite,” and the SSA suggests “summon.” It may also be necessary to include an additional verb here. Here is another way to translate this:

who calls you to share in (GNT)

His own kingdom and glory: There are two ways to understand this:

1. God called the Thessalonians to share in two things: His own kingdom and His own...glory. (BSB, NIV, RSV, NET, GNT, GW, KJV, REB, CEV)
2. This could be interpreted as a hendiadys. This means that the second noun, glory, modifies the first noun, kingdom. This would then be translated “his glorious kingdom”. (NCV, SSA)

Although the structure of this part of the verse in Greek gives some support to the second option, many commentators prefer the first option. This means that God’s kingdom and his glory are two related, yet separate, things that the Thessalonians could expect to share in if they behaved in a way that was worthy of God (2:12a). It therefore is recommended that you follow the first option (1).

The expectation of sharing in God’s kingdom and glory would also be an encouragement to continue believing despite persecution. Compare with Paul’s words in Romans 8:18.

kingdom: In this context, this does not refer to a geographical region, but to God’s rule over his people. To share in God’s kingdom then means “to be the people over whom God will rule.” See kingdom in the glossary. See also “Kingdom of God”, sense 1 in KBT.

glory: In this context, to share God’s glory means to share his greatness/majesty. See “glory”, sense 3b in KBT and in the glossary.

1 Thessalonians 2:13

Section 2:13–16: Paul again thanked God for the way the Thessalonians had accepted the gospel

Paul also thanked God that the new Thessalonian believers had accepted the message that he and his companions taught them as words that truly came from God. The result was that other Thessalonians caused them to suffer just as fellow Jews had caused the new believers in Judea to suffer. Furthermore, Jews had also killed Jesus and the prophets before him. The Jews had also persecuted Paul and his companions and tried to stop them from telling non-Jews how they could be saved. Because the Jews had continued to sin greatly for a long period of time, God would soon punish them.

2:13a

And we continually thank God because,

- ¶ There is another reason that we^(excl) never stop thanking God. It is that
- ¶ We^(excl) also continually thank God because,

And we continually thank God because: This new section resumes the theme of thanking God that ended at 1 Thessalonians 1:10. In this verse Paul wrote additional reasons to thank God for the way that the Thessalonians had accepted the gospel.

because: In this verse Paul gave another reason why he thanked God for the Thessalonians, that is, he thanked God because they had accepted his preaching as a message from God.

2:13b

when you received the word of God that you heard from us,

- when you listened to the message from God which we^(excl) preached to you,

when you received the word of God: Notice that this is not the main clause of the verse but a temporal clause that gives the time when the main event (2:13c) occurred.

the word of God: In this verse this phrase is not referring to the Bible but to Paul's message. It was "a message from God," "a message that originated with God."

2:13c

you accepted it not as the word of men,

- you accepted it, not as a message from human beings,
- you recognised that it was not a message which people had invented.

the word of men: In contrast to "the word of God" in 2:13b, this refers to a message that some person has invented.

men: As in 2:4b, the Greek word *anthropos*, which the BSB translates as men, is a word that means humans beings, male and female. It is not limited to males.

2:13d

but as the true word of God—

- but as what it truly is, the message from God.
- Instead, you recognized it as it truly is, God's message.

2:13d-e

the true word of God ... which: In the Greek text it is not clear to whom or what this refers. There are two possibilities:

1. It refers to "the word of God." This is the interpretation accepted by most commentators and English versions.
2. It refers directly to "God." It would therefore be translated "who" rather than "which." For example:

For God is at work in you (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1) as do most versions and commentators. God used his word / message to "work in" the Thessalonians.

2:13e

the word which is now at work in you who believe.

- And this message from God is now working in you who believe in Christ.
- And God is using his message to help you believers to behave in a way which pleases him.

is now at work in you who believe: This means that the word of God was affecting the way that the Thessalonians were behaving and thinking. In some languages it is not possible to talk about a message "working." If this is true in your language you could say, "God is using his message that we are preaching to cause you to behave more in the manner that pleases him."

who believe: In this verse Paul did not give an object for the verb "believe," so it is not clear exactly what he was referring to. There are four possibilities:

1. Jesus Christ
2. God
3. both God and Jesus
4. the gospel

If you can leave the verb "believe" without an object in your translation, you should do so. However, if you cannot do this, it is recommended that you use Jesus Christ as the object of the verb, as this is supported by most commentaries.

1 Thessalonians 2:14

Section 2:13–16: Paul again thanked God for the way the Thessalonians had accepted the gospel

Paul also thanked God that the new Thessalonian believers had accepted the message that he and his companions taught them as words that truly came from God. The result was that other Thessalonians caused them to suffer just as fellow Jews had caused the new believers in Judea to suffer. Furthermore, Jews had also killed Jesus and the prophets before him. The Jews had also persecuted Paul and his companions and tried to stop them from telling non-Jews how they could be saved. Because the Jews had continued to sin greatly for a long period of time, God would soon punish them.

2:14a

For you, brothers, became imitators of the churches of God in Judea that are in Christ Jesus.

- Brothers, what proves that God’s message began to work in you is that what happened to the groups of believers in Christ Jesus that are in the land of Judea also happened to you,

For: Here Paul gave the grounds for what he had just said in 2:13. Commentators do not agree about which part of 2:13 this verse is connected to. There are two possibilities:

1. It is connected only to 2:13e. Paul was saying that, because the Thessalonians had become imitators of the congregations in Judea, this showed that God’s message was working in them.
2. It is connected to 2:13b–d. Paul was saying that, because the Thessalonians had become imitators of the congregations in Judea, this showed that they had accepted Paul’s message.

Commentators are equally divided and English versions are ambiguous, either using “for” or no explicit link. The Display follows the first option.

brothers: See the note on 1:4.

you...became imitators: The meaning here is slightly different from that in 1:6a, where the same verb is used. Paul was not saying that the Thessalonians had deliberately imitated the Judean Christians. Instead, in this section Paul wanted to say that the Thessalonians did not intentionally imitate the Judean churches. The Thessalonians had not asked people to persecute them. They had simply obeyed the message that Paul had preached. The result was that people had persecuted them just as the Jews had persecuted the Christians in the Judea. If you use the same expression here as you used in 1:6a, it would give the impression that the Thessalonians had deliberately copied the Judean believers. Therefore, you should use a different expression here. For example:

your experiences have been like those of God’s churches in Christ that are in Judea (NCV)

Another way to express it is:

the same things have happened to you as happened to God’s churches in Christ that are in Judea.

the churches of God: Paul was speaking about groups of people who believe in Christ Jesus. As in 1:1b, you should avoid a translation of the word “church” that would make people think of a building. See church in the glossary.

in Judea: When Paul was writing this letter, Judea was a province in the land of Israel ruled by the Romans.

that are in Christ Jesus: The word in is difficult to translate here. In this context it probably means “those who believe in Christ Jesus” or “those who belong to Christ Jesus” (GNT).

Christ Jesus: Paul sometimes wrote Christ Jesus and sometimes “Jesus Christ.” There is no difference in meaning. However, you should translate what Paul wrote unless this would confuse your readers.

2:14b

You suffered from your own countrymen the very things they suffered from the Jews,

- that is, your fellow countrymen who do not believe in Jesus caused you to suffer just as the Jews caused the groups of believers who were their fellow countrymen to suffer.

In the Greek text this part of the verse begins with *hoti*, which the BSB has left implicit. This word in Greek has many meanings. In this context there are two possible meanings:

1. It means that what follows is a restatement of the previous sentence. This would then mean that the way the Thessalonians were like the Judean churches was that they had suffered persecution.
2. It means “since, for” and means here that, since the Thessalonians were suffering persecution, that suffering showed that they were imitators of the Judean churches (KJV, RSV).

Many English versions follow the BSB and omit any connecting word here. It is recommended that you follow the first option (1), as it makes the best sense in the context.

1 Thessalonians 2:15

Section 2:13–16: Paul again thanked God for the way the Thessalonians had accepted the gospel

Paul also thanked God that the new Thessalonian believers had accepted the message that he and his companions taught them as words that truly came from God. The result was that other Thessalonians caused them to suffer just as fellow Jews had caused the new believers in Judea to suffer. Furthermore, Jews had also killed Jesus and the prophets before him. The Jews had also persecuted Paul and his companions and tried to stop them from telling non-Jews how they could be saved. Because the Jews had continued to sin greatly for a long period of time, God would soon punish them.

2:15a**who killed both the Lord Jesus and their own prophets,**

- It was Jews who killed the Lord Jesus and some of God's prophets.

who killed both the Lord Jesus and their own prophets: Here Paul refers to the Jews as a collective whole across time. The Jews who killed ...their own prophets refers to people who killed some of the Old Testament prophets from many generations ago. This refers to different people than those who plotted to kill Jesus, which happened only 20 years or so before Paul wrote this letter. In both cases, although the Jews are referred to as a whole, it was only certain people, or certain groups of people who wanted to have them killed.

who killed both the Lord Jesus: Although it was Roman soldiers who actually crucified Jesus, it was the Jewish leaders who handed Jesus over to the Romans and who were therefore responsible for his death. Notice that this group of Jews was not the same group of Jews who had persecuted the Judean churches (2:14b).

their own prophets: Paul was referring to the Old Testament prophets here. A literal translation of Paul's words in some languages may imply that the Jews had killed all the prophets, so you may need to make it clear that it was only some prophets who were killed. For example:

who killed some of their own prophets

This is not referring to a specific event where many prophets were killed. It is referring broadly to the many generations during the Old Testament period where prophets were killed. Translate in a way that refers to many years of repeated incidents with different generations of people.

2:15b**and drove us out as well.**

- And it was Jews who also chased us^(excl) from many places where we^(excl) preached.

and drove us out as well: The Greek word *ekdiōkō*, which the BSB translates as drove...out, can have several meanings. The commentators disagree about what it means in this verse. There are two possibilities:

1. Paul used it with its literal meaning "to drive out." This is what the Jews did to Paul in Thessalonica and Berea (Acts 17:5–10, 13–15). (BSB, RSV, NIV, REB, CEV, NCV)

2. Paul used the word with the secondary meaning "to persecute." The way that Paul and his companions were being "driven out" is just one example of how they were "being persecuted." (KJV, GNT, GW, NET, NJB)

In the context, the first option (1) makes the most sense and is therefore recommended. The Thessalonians would easily remember how Paul and his companions had been chased away from Thessalonica.

us: Most commentators agree that *us* refers specifically to Paul, Silvanus, and Timothy.

2:15c**They are displeasing to God**

- By behaving this way they anger God.

They are displeasing to God: Commentators do not agree about how this should be understood here. There are two possibilities:

1. The Jews were displeasing to God by the way that they were hindering Paul from preaching to the non-Jews (2:16a).
2. The Jews were displeasing to God by the way that they were persecuting Christians.

Most English versions are ambiguous. It is recommended that you leave your translation ambiguous here if that is possible. However if you wish to make the connection clear, the Display shows one way to express the first interpretation (1).

2:15d-2:16a**and hostile to all men, hindering us from telling the Gentiles how they may be saved:**

The Jews were hostile to all people because they were trying to prevent believing people from sharing the Gospel with others. In Acts 13:45, 13:49, 14:2, 14:19, 17:5, and 17:13 there are examples of how the Jews tried to stop Paul from preaching to the non-Jews. They did not want God to save the non-Jews and cause them to also become part of his people. Here is another way to translate these verse parts:

they oppose everybody, trying to stop us^(excl) from speaking to the non-Jews

2:15d**and hostile to all men,**

- They oppose everybody,
- They act as enemies to everyone,

1 Thessalonians 2:16

Section 2:13–16: Paul again thanked God for the way the Thessalonians had accepted the gospel

Paul also thanked God that the new Thessalonian believers had accepted the message that he and his companions taught them as words that truly came from God. The result was that other Thessalonians caused them to suffer just as fellow Jews had caused the new believers in Judea to suffer. Furthermore, Jews had also killed Jesus and the prophets before him. The Jews had also persecuted Paul and his companions and tried to stop them from telling non-Jews how they could be saved. Because the Jews had continued to sin greatly for a long period of time, God would soon punish them.

2:16a

hindering us from telling the Gentiles how they may be saved.

- trying to stop us^(excl) from telling the non-Jews that/ how God can save them instead of punishing them because of their sins.

Gentiles: Gentiles were all people who were not Jews. See the word Gentile in the glossary.

2:16b

As a result, they continue to heap up their sins to full capacity;

- So, just as people add things to make a pile, the Jews have continually added more and more sins until they have reached God's limit.
- They keep adding sin to sin, until at last God must punish them.
- And so the result of the Jews doing all these bad things is that they are sinning so greatly that God cannot ignore it.

As a result, they continue to heap up their sins to full capacity: The grammatical construction in Greek in this part of the verse can be understood in two ways:

1. It indicates the result of the Jews' actions. This means that they had tried hard to stop Paul. That resulted in them adding to their previous sins of killing the prophets and Jesus, which they had done thinking (mistakenly) that they were pleasing God. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, GW, NJB, NRSV, NCV, NLT)
2. It indicates the purpose of their actions. Some translations suggest that the Jews knew that they were sinning. (KJV, RSV, JB)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1), along with the majority of English versions.

heap up their sins: This is a metaphor. Paul was comparing the way that they sinned more and more to someone adding to a pile of rubbish. This illustrated how God had been patient from even Old Testament times. He had figuratively allowed the pile of sins to grow high. But finally, Paul said, God had become very angry and would soon punish them. See the note on 2:16c.

2:16c

the utmost wrath has come upon them.

- The result is that finally God is angry and will soon punish them.
- And now at last God is certainly about to punish them.

the...wrath: Here Paul implies that the wrath is God's wrath. Many English versions have made this explicit in the text. For example:

The wrath of God (NIV)

utmost: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as utmost is more literally "in/to the end." This phrase can have several meanings. There are two primary possibilities:

1. The phrase goes with "has come upon them" and indicates that these people are experiencing wrath "finally" or "in the end." (RSV, ESV, NIV, CEV, NCV, GNT, GW, NJB)
2. The phrase goes with "wrath" and indicates that this "wrath" is extreme or complete. (BSB, KJV, REB, NET)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1), along with the majority of English versions.

has come upon them: Commentators do not agree about the timing of this. The tense of the verb in Greek would seem to indicate that the judgment had already taken place before Paul wrote the letter. However, Paul may have used the past tense here to show that this was something certain to happen.

Many English versions simply follow the Greek past tense, though the JB and GW use a present tense verb. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Now God has finally become angry and will punish them. (CEV)

You need to choose the tense in your language which most clearly conveys that God's judgment was something that was going to happen very soon and therefore was as certain as if it had already happened.

1 Thessalonians 2:17

Section 2:17–3:5: Paul explained that he wanted very much to visit the Thessalonians again

Paragraph 2:17–20

In these verses Paul affirmed that he and his companions had felt distressed because they had had to leave Thessalonica suddenly. He explained how they had tried to revisit the Thessalonian believers, but Satan had prevented them from doing that.

2:17a

Brothers, although we were torn away from you for a short time

- ¶ However, brothers, a short time after we^(excl) were forced to leave you
- ¶ However, brothers, soon after people caused us^(excl) to be separated from you

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction (de) that is often translated as “But” (see the NIV). This conjunction does not introduce a contrast with the previous verse. Instead, it indicates that Paul was changing from the topic of what the Jews did to him and his companions to a new topic. The new topic was how he and his companions felt when they had to leave Thessalonica. Some English versions, including the BSB, do not translate this conjunction. Introduce this verse in a natural way in your language.

Brothers: See the note on 1:4.

although we were torn away from you: See Acts 17:1–10. Local Jews had persecuted Paul and his companions and forced them to leave Thessalonica hurriedly. The passive form of the Greek verb *aporphanizō* is used here. While the BSB translates it as torn away, it literally means “to be orphaned,” that is, to lose both parents by them dying. However, in this context this word is used figuratively and means “to be separated from.” Paul probably used the term to express how sad he felt because he had to leave Thessalonica suddenly and be separated from the Thessalonians.

for a short time: A short time after Paul left Thessalonica, he began to desire to see the Thessalonians again. We do not know how long this time was, so you should try to avoid using a precise time word in your translation.

2:17b

(in person, not in heart),

- (although we^(excl) were unable to be with you, we^(excl) still thought about you often),
- physically (although we still thought about you),

(in person, not in heart): The Greek uses an idiom here which literally means: “in face, not in heart.” Paul meant that, although he and his companions were not physically present in Thessalonica, they continually thought about the believers there. You might have an idiom in your language that has this meaning. If not, one way to translate the verse is:

we ourselves were not with you, but we were always thinking about you (UBS Handbook, page 48)

This part of the verse is a parenthesis that further describes the verb “torn away” in 2:17a.

2:17c

our desire to see you face to face was even more intense.

- since we^(excl) desired greatly to be with you again, we^(excl) tried very hard to return to you.
- we^(excl) very much wanted to see you again, so we^(excl) tried very earnestly to do that.

our desire to see you face to face was even more intense: The Greek verb *spoudazō*, which the BSB translates as was...more intense, can mean one of two things:

1. “to make a great effort, to try very strongly”. (NIV, RSV, GNT, CEV, KJV, NCV, NLT).
2. “to be very eager, to want very much”. (BSB, NET, NJB, NRSV, REB, SSA)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1), as it fits the immediate context of 2:18, where Paul explained further how hard he had tried to see the Thessalonians again.

face to face: Here Paul uses the same idiom he used in 2:17b. He means that he wanted to be physically present with the Thessalonians. Consider translating this phrase as you translated the similar phrase in 2:17b.

1 Thessalonians 2:18

Section 2:17–3:5: Paul explained that he wanted very much to visit the Thessalonians again

Paragraph 2:17–20

In these verses Paul affirmed that he and his companions had felt distressed because they had had to leave Thessalonica suddenly. He explained how they had tried to revisit the Thessalonian believers, but Satan had prevented them from doing that.

2:18a**For we wanted to come to you—**

- This was because we^(excl) really did want to come/go and visit you again.

For: In Greek, 2:18 begins with the word *dioti*. This word can mean one of two things in this context:

1. It means “since, for, because” and it introduces the grounds/basis for Paul and his companions making every effort to see the Thessalonians. (BSB, NIV, RSV, NET, SSA)
2. It means “therefore” and it introduces the result of Paul’s great desire to see them again. (KJV, REB)

Many English versions leave this connection implicit and therefore their translations are ambiguous. Most commentaries support the first option, and it is recommended that you also follow option (1).

2:18b**indeed I, Paul, tried again and again—but Satan obstructed us.**

- In fact I, Paul, tried several times to return to you, but Satan stopped/prevented us.^(excl)

indeed I, Paul, tried again and again: There is no verb in this part of the verse in the Greek text, but it is probably best to understand the implied verb as being the same verb as in 2:17c: “tried hard to come.”

Here Paul only referred to himself rather than including Silvanus and Timothy. He was not implying that they did not try to visit the Thessalonians. Rather, he was emphasizing his own personal effort.

but Satan obstructed us: It was human beings who caused trouble for Paul (Acts 17:5–9), but Paul attributed their actions to the work of Satan. See “Satan” in KBT and in the glossary.

us: Paul referred once more to himself and his companions after talking about himself alone earlier in the verse.

1 Thessalonians 2:19**Section 2:17–3:5: Paul explained that he wanted very much to visit the Thessalonians again****Paragraph 2:17–20**

In these verses Paul affirmed that he and his companions had felt distressed because they had had to leave Thessalonica suddenly. He explained how they had tried to revisit the Thessalonian believers, but Satan had prevented them from doing that.

2:19

In this verse Paul told the Thessalonians one reason why he wanted to see them again. He gave the reason by using a rhetorical question, which he immediately answered. If such a question is unnatural in your language, you could translate this verse without using a question. For example:

You^(plural) are our hope, our joy, and our crown of righteous pride. Because of you^(plural), we will glory in the presence of our ^(incl) Lord Jesus when he comes.

2:19a**After all, who is our hope,**

- For you are the reason for our^(excl) hope;
- We^(excl) want to visit you again because you cause us^(excl) to hope,

who is our hope: Paul meant that the Thessalonians would be the cause of his hope, the reason for his hope. He and his companions were confident that when Jesus returned, the Thessalonians would not be ashamed to meet him, because they had strongly trusted in him. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

you will give us hope (CEV)

It is difficult to know how much of the meaning of this expression a translator should make explicit in the translation. The Display shows some ways of translating this part of the verse. If you want to make more information explicit, you could say:

it is you whom we (excl) confidently expect to be strongly trusting in Jesus.

2:19b**our joy,**

- you are the reason for our^(excl) joy;
- and you cause us^(excl) to rejoice,

our joy: The Thessalonians would also be a cause of joy for Paul. When Jesus returned, they would also cause Paul and his companions to rejoice, because they had continued to believe firmly in Jesus Christ.

2:19c**our crown of boasting,**

- you are the reason why we^(excl) will be proud.
- and you cause us^(excl) to be proud of our work.

- and you are something we^(excl) can be proud of, like an athlete can be proud of the wreath he has won.

our crown: In Greek culture, one of the symbols of great honor was a wreath of laurel leaves that was placed on the head of an athlete who had won a race. Paul was using this image in a metaphor here. He described the Thessalonians as his “wreath of honor.” This means that, just as the laurel wreath showed that an athlete had won a race, so the fact that the Thessalonians strongly believed in Jesus would show that Paul’s work in preaching the gospel had been successful.

of boasting: The Greek word for boasting here is not the same word as is usually translated “glory” in the New Testament. It is a word that means “reason for boasting, pride.” The word “boasting” in English often has a negative meaning, and a better translation is “of which we will be proud.” Here Paul means that he, Silvanus, and Timothy will be proud of the “crown.” See glory in the glossary, meaning 2.

2:19d

if it is not you yourselves

- Yes, it is you who will be our^(excl) hope, joy and crown

if it is not you yourselves: Here Paul emphasizes the fact that the Thessalonians would indeed be his “hope,” “joy,” and “crown.” You could include Paul’s emphasis by beginning the verse part with something like, “It is indeed you....”

2:19e

in the presence of our Lord Jesus at His coming?

- before our^(incl) Lord Jesus on the day when he returns.

in the presence of our Lord Jesus at His coming: This phrase is connected with 2:19a–d, not just 2:19d. There is no verb in the first part of the verse (2:19a–d), so all translators need to decide what tense of verb to use. Many English versions use the present tense in order to be consistent with 2:20. However, 2:19e makes it clear that here Paul was talking about the future. So in some languages, it will be better to use a future tense. You should use whichever tense of verb makes most sense in your language in this context.

1 Thessalonians 2:20

Section 2:17–3:5: Paul explained that he wanted very much to visit the Thessalonians again

Paragraph 2:17–20

In these verses Paul affirmed that he and his companions had felt distressed because they had had to leave Thessalonica suddenly. He explained how they had

tried to revisit the Thessalonian believers, but Satan had prevented them from doing that.

2:20

You are indeed our glory and our joy.

- Indeed, you are the reason we^(excl) are proud and rejoice.
- Truly you cause us^(excl) to be proud of you and to rejoice about you.

You are indeed our glory and our joy: The clause You are indeed our glory and our joy repeats in a positive/declarative statement some of what Paul said in the rhetorical question in 2:19.

glory: This is not the same word that the BSB translated as “boasting” in 2:19c. Here Paul used the normal NT word for glory, *doxa*. In this context there are two possible meanings:

1. It has a similar meaning to that in 2:19c, even though the Greek words are different. Therefore, it means that Paul and his companions were proud of the Thessalonians. See glory in the glossary, meaning 2.
2. It means that Paul and his companions will receive “glory,” that is, that Christ will praise/honor them because the Thessalonians continued to believe strongly in Jesus Christ.

No English version clearly supports the second view, though some commentators do. So it is recommended that you follow the first option (1).

1 Thessalonians 3:1

Section 2:17–3:5: Paul explained that he wanted very much to visit the Thessalonians again

Paragraph 3:1–5

Since Paul and his companions were not all able to return to Thessalonica, they decided to send Timothy alone. The purpose of Timothy’s visit was to strengthen and encourage the Thessalonians to continue believing in Christ even when people persecuted them. As Christians, they should expect that other people would cause them to suffer. Paul was very concerned about them, because he feared that the Thessalonians had been persecuted so severely that the devil had been able to tempt them to stop following Christ.

3:1a

So when we could bear it no longer,

- ¶ So, when we^(excl) could no longer bear not being able to see you again,

- ¶ Therefore, when we^(excl) could not tolerate being separated from you any longer,

So: This Greek conjunction, *dio*, indicates that this paragraph, 3:1–5, is the result of 2:17–20. That is, the result of Paul making every effort to return to the Thessalonians was that, when he discovered that he could not go to Thessalonica, he sent Timothy instead to find out how the Thessalonians were. Here is another way to translate this transition:

therefore

when we could bear it no longer: In Greek, the verb that the BSB translates as *we could bear it* is a participle. That means there are two possible ways to translate it:

1. As a time clause, that is, it gives the time at which 3:1b occurred. When Paul could no longer tolerate not knowing how the Thessalonians were doing, he sent Timothy to find out about them. (BSB, NIV, NCV, NJB, NLT, KJV, RSV, REB, SSA)
2. As the reason why Paul sent Timothy to the Thessalonians: Because Paul could no longer tolerate not knowing what was happening in Thessalonica, he sent Timothy to find out. (GNT, GW)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1), along with the majority of English translations.

we could bear it no longer: It may be necessary for you to make explicit what Paul and his companions could no longer bear. For example: “when we could no longer bear not knowing how you were doing.”

we: This is an exclusive pronoun, since it refers to Paul and his companions, but not to the Thessalonian believers.

bear: The verb *bear* means to “carry the weight of, endure”. Paul and his companions could not tolerate waiting longer to know how the Thessalonians were doing spiritually.

3:1b

we were willing to be left on our own in Athens.

- we^{(excl)(dual)} willingly decided to remain by ourselves^{(excl)(dual)} in the city of Athens.

we were willing: This translates the same Greek word that was translated “we were delighted to” in 2:8b. In this context it means “we decided, it seemed good to us.” This refers to Paul and Silvanus (Silas) since they were the ones who were left in Athens. If your language has a dual form, you may wish to use it here. For example:

we^(dual) were willing

to be left on our own in Athens: Timothy and Silas had joined Paul sometime after he got to Athens (Acts 17:15–16). It was sometime later that Paul sent Timothy back to Thessalonica. We do not know exact times for these events.

1 Thessalonians 3:2

Section 2:17–3:5: Paul explained that he wanted very much to visit the Thessalonians again

Paragraph 3:1–5

Since Paul and his companions were not all able to return to Thessalonica, they decided to send Timothy alone. The purpose of Timothy’s visit was to strengthen and encourage the Thessalonians to continue believing in Christ even when people persecuted them. As Christians, they should expect that other people would cause them to suffer. Paul was very concerned about them, because he feared that the Thessalonians had been persecuted so severely that the devil had been able to tempt them to stop following Christ.

3:2a

We sent Timothy, our brother and fellow worker for God in the gospel of Christ,

- In our place we^(excl) sent Timothy to you. He is our^(excl) brother in the family of God and he works with God to tell the good news about Christ to others.

our brother and fellow worker for God in the gospel of Christ: This verse contains a long description of Timothy in the middle of a narrative sentence. In some languages, wording it this way may interrupt the flow of the sentence to have this information about Timothy between Paul’s statement that “we sent” him and his description of the reason why he and Silvanus sent him. Paul provided this information in order to confirm that he had authorized Timothy to visit the Thessalonians and that Timothy was fully qualified to help them. In some languages it may be necessary to use a separate sentence for Paul’s description of Timothy, then return to the main theme in a new sentence afterward. For example:

and send Timothy to you. Timothy, our brother, works with us for God and helps us tell people the Good news about Christ. We sent him to strengthen and encourage you in your faith. (NCV)

our brother: For the term *brother*, see the note on 1:4.

fellow worker for God: There is a textual problem in this verse. There are three different Greek texts followed by English versions:

1. The text reads “God’s fellow worker”. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, NLT, NRSV, REB, NCV, SSA)
2. The text reads “God’s servant”. (RSV, GW, NJB)
3. The text reads “God’s servant and our fellow worker”. (KJV, CEV)

Most Greek scholars agree that the first option (1) is the correct one, so it is recommended that you follow it.

However not all scholars agree on what the phrase that the BSB translates as fellow worker for God means. There are two possibilities:

1. It means that Timothy worked together with God, that they worked together to spread the gospel. (ESV, REB, NIV)
2. It means that Timothy was a fellow-worker of Paul and Silas and that all three worked together for God. (BSB, NIV11, GNT, NCV, NET, NLT, NRSV, SSA)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1).

in the gospel of Christ: The Greek text has no verb in this part of the verse, but most modern English versions include a verb here, such as “spreading” (NIV) or “preaching” (GNT). It will probably be necessary to do something similar in your translation.

the gospel of Christ: In this context, this means “the gospel about Christ.”

3:2b

to strengthen and encourage you in your faith,

- We^(excl) sent him to you to help you strongly believe in Christ and to encourage you to continue believing in him,

to strengthen...you in your faith: Paul intended that Timothy should strengthen the Thessalonians inwardly/spiritually, that he should help them believe more strongly in Christ.

and encourage you in your faith: The second thing that Paul intended was that Timothy should encourage the Thessalonians to keep on believing.

in your faith: Notice that this phrase goes with both verbs, strengthen and encourage.

1 Thessalonians 3:3

Section 2:17–3:5: Paul explained that he wanted very much to visit the Thessalonians again

Paragraph 3:1–5

Since Paul and his companions were not all able to return to Thessalonica, they decided to send Timothy alone. The purpose of Timothy’s visit was to strengthen and encourage the Thessalonians to continue believing in Christ even when people persecuted them. As Christians, they should expect that other people would cause them to suffer. Paul was very concerned about them, because he feared that the Thessalonians had been persecuted so severely that the devil had been able to tempt them to stop following Christ.

3:3a

so that none of you would be shaken by these trials.

- so that these persecutions that you are suffering would not disturb anyone of you in your faith.
- so that none of you should become discouraged and stop believing in Christ because others are causing you to suffer.

so that none of you would be shaken: The Greek verb *sainō*, which the BSB translates as shaken, has two possible meanings:

1. It means “disturbed, unsettled”. (BSB, NIV, NET, CEV, NCV, NLT, GW, RSV, REB, NJB, KJV)
2. It means “deceived.” The GNT has interpreted this to mean “turn back.”

Although the second meaning “deceive” is the most common meaning in Greek for this verb, in this context the first option (1) makes better sense and has the best support from commentaries and English versions, so it is recommended that you follow it in your translation.

by these trials: This phrase refers to the persecutions that the Thessalonian believers were suffering. The same Greek word was translated “suffering” in 1:6c.

3:3b

For you know that we are destined for this.

- You know well that God has decided that we^(incl) should be persecuted like this.
- For you know well that we^(incl) will suffer in this way because it is God’s will for us^(incl).

For you know: The Greek text say literally, “For you yourselves know.” These words show that Paul was again reminding the Thessalonians of what they already knew because he had taught it to them while he was in Thessalonica.

we are destined for this: The Greek verb *keimai*, which the BSB has translated as *are destined*, has many meanings. In this context it means “appointed, destined, ordained.” Paul did not say who had destined people for the trials of 3:3a, but he apparently meant that it was God. Make sure the word you choose to translate this verb does not give the impression that God is a dictator who, without good reason, likes to make people suffer. Here is another way to translate this clause:

such persecutions are part of God’s will for us
(GNT)

we: Here this refers to all Christians, not just Paul and his companions.

this: The word *this* refers to the “trials” in 3:3a.

1 Thessalonians 3:4

Section 2:17–3:5: Paul explained that he wanted very much to visit the Thessalonians again

Paragraph 3:1–5

Since Paul and his companions were not all able to return to Thessalonica, they decided to send Timothy alone. The purpose of Timothy’s visit was to strengthen and encourage the Thessalonians to continue believing in Christ even when people persecuted them. As Christians, they should expect that other people would cause them to suffer. Paul was very concerned about them, because he feared that the Thessalonians had been persecuted so severely that the devil had been able to tempt them to stop following Christ.

3:4a

Indeed, when we were with you, we kept warning you

- You know this because we^(excl) kept telling you before, when we^(excl) were with you,

Indeed: This translates the Greek phrase *kai gar*, which literally means “and for.” Many English versions translate it “for.” Paul used this phrase to show that 3:4a was the reason for his statement in 3:3b. That is, the Thessalonians knew they were destined to be persecuted because Paul and his companions had told them so.

we kept warning you: The Greek verb *prolegō*, which the BSB translates as *warning*, means “to foretell, to tell something before it happens.” The BSB has left implicit the idea of “before it happens,” as this is clear from the context. In your translation, do not use a

word that means divination or prophecy or a warning not to do something. Paul had told the Thessalonians that they would suffer because that is what happens to all Christians.

The form of the Greek verb suggests that Paul and his companions had told the Thessalonians this several times. This is why the BSB has translated it as *kept warning*.

3:4b

that we would suffer persecution;

- that it was certain that we^(incl) all would be persecuted.
- that people would certainly persecute us^(incl).

that we would suffer persecution: The Greek verb *mellō* followed by a second verb (in this case *suffer persecution*) means that the second action is inevitable, something that is certain to happen.

we: This refers to all believers, not just Paul and his companions.

3:4c

and as you know, it has come to pass.

- And you know that this is exactly what has happened to you.
- And you have seen that this is what has happened to you.

it has come to pass: The Thessalonian believers had already experienced persecution for their faith, so they knew that believers suffer because they obey God.

1 Thessalonians 3:5

Section 2:17–3:5: Paul explained that he wanted very much to visit the Thessalonians again

Paragraph 3:1–5

Since Paul and his companions were not all able to return to Thessalonica, they decided to send Timothy alone. The purpose of Timothy’s visit was to strengthen and encourage the Thessalonians to continue believing in Christ even when people persecuted them. As Christians, they should expect that other people would cause them to suffer. Paul was very concerned about them, because he feared that the Thessalonians had been persecuted so severely that the devil had been able to tempt them to stop following Christ.

3:5a

For this reason, when I could bear it no longer,

- That is why, when I could no longer bear not knowing whether or not you still believed in Christ,

- Because I knew that you were being persecuted and when I could not tolerate/bear any longer not knowing how you were doing,

For this reason: Commentators do not agree about what this refers to. There are two possibilities:

1. It refers back to 3:4. Paul was saying that, because he knew that the Thessalonians were being persecuted, he was anxious about them. (GNT, NLT, REB, NJB, SSA)
2. It refers forward to the rest of 3:5. Paul was saying that, because he could no longer stand not knowing how the Thessalonians were, he had sent Timothy. In this case, this verse repeats 3:1a, which contains a similar phrase in Greek.

Many English versions are ambiguous, and it may be possible for you to translate this in a way that leaves both possibilities open. However, if that is not possible, it is recommended that you follow the first option (1), along with the majority of English versions that are not ambiguous.

3:5b

I sent to find out about your faith,

- I sent Timothy to find out whether or not you still firmly believed in Christ.

I sent: The Greek text does not explicitly say whom Paul sent, but from the context it is clear that he was referring to Timothy. You may need to make this explicit in your translation. For example:

I sent Timothy (CEV)

to find out about your faith: Paul was not spying, nor did he want to know what facts the Thessalonians believed. He wanted to know whether they still firmly believed in Jesus Christ.

3:5c

for fear that the tempter had somehow tempted you

- I did this because I was afraid that perhaps the one who tempts people might have tempted you and might have caused you to stop believing in Christ,

for fear that: These words translate the Greek phrase *mē pōs*, which means “lest.” Paul was concerned that the Thessalonians might have stopped believing in Christ.

the tempter: This refers to Satan, the devil. The same expression is also used in Matthew 4:3. If your readers would not understand that this term refers to Satan, you could:

- make explicit that it refers to Satan, for example, use an expression such as “Satan, the one who tempts people.”
- replace the term “the tempter” with “Satan” or “the devil”. For example:

Satan (CEV)

devil (NCV)

- use a footnote or a note in the glossary.

had somehow tempted you: In some languages the same word is used for “tempting” and “testing” and it is necessary to specify what someone is tempting people to do. In this context, Paul meant that he was afraid that the devil might have successfully tempted the Thessalonians to stop believing in Jesus.

3:5d

and caused our labor to be in vain.

- and that the hard work that we^(excl) had done among you to help you believe in Christ would turn out to be useless.
- and because I was afraid that the effort that we^(excl) had made among you had been wasted.

our labor: This refers to the effort Paul and his companions had made as they worked and preached so that the Thessalonians would follow Christ.

to be in vain: However, if Satan had succeeded in tempting the Thessalonians to stop following Christ, all that effort would have been worthless.

1 Thessalonians 3:6

Section 3:6–13: Timothy had visited the Thessalonians and brought Paul an encouraging report

Paragraph 3:6–10

Timothy had returned from Thessalonica with the good news that the Thessalonians still affectionately remembered Paul and his companions and that they still trusted in God and loved other people. This encouraged Paul greatly. The news made him pray even more fervently that he and his companions might be able to visit the Thessalonians again.

3:6a

But just now, Timothy has returned from his visit

- ¶ But now Timothy has come back to us^(excl) after visiting you

But: The way this verse begins in Greek indicates that Paul was beginning a new section. It possibly also contrasts the joy that Paul felt when Timothy brought

his good news with the fear that Paul had been writing about in 3:5.

just now: Biblical scholars do not agree about which other word the Greek word *arti* (now) is connected to. There are two possibilities:

1. It is connected to the verb “come.” Most English versions follow this.
2. It is connected to the verb “reassured” in 3:7b. This is probably what the RSV follows.

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1), as the position of *arti* in the Greek sentence suggests that it is probably connected to the verb “come.”

3:6b

with the good news about your faith, your love,

- and has told us^(excl) the good news that you still believe in Christ and you still love other people.

the good news about your faith: This refers to the good news that the Thessalonians were still continuing to believe strongly in Christ.

your love: Paul did not make explicit here whom the Thessalonians loved. It could refer to God, Jesus, Paul and his companions, the other Thessalonian believers, or just people in general. All are possible and suggested in commentaries. However, most commentators think that here Paul meant love for other people. If possible, you should leave this ambiguous, since it is in ambiguous the Greek text. But if you must supply an object for the verb “love” in your language, you should say “love other people.”

3:6c

and the fond memories you have preserved,

- He has also told us^(excl) that you still remember us^(excl) affectionately

and the fond memories you have preserved: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you always think about us affectionately

every time you remember us, it makes you happy

3:6d

longing to see us

- and that you greatly desire to see us^(excl) again,

longing to see us: The verb longing means “greatly desiring.”

3:6e

just as we long to see you.

- just as we^(excl) greatly desire to see you.

just as: There are two different ways to understand what just as means:

1. It means “in the same way as”. (BSB, KJV, NIV, RSV, NASB, GW).
2. It means “just as much as”. (GNT, REB, NJB, CEV, NCV).

It is recommended that you follow the first meaning (1).

we long to see you: In Greek there is no verb in this part of the sentence, but the BSB has repeated the verb long in order to make the meaning clear.

1 Thessalonians 3:7

Section 3:6–13: Timothy had visited the Thessalonians and brought Paul an encouraging report

Paragraph 3:6–10

Timothy had returned from Thessalonica with the good news that the Thessalonians still affectionately remembered Paul and his companions and that they still trusted in God and loved other people. This encouraged Paul greatly. The news made him pray even more fervently that he and his companions might be able to visit the Thessalonians again.

3:7a

For this reason, brothers, in all our distress and persecution,

- Because of that which Timothy has told us^(excl), brothers, even though we^(excl) suffer much because people are persecuting us,^(excl)

For this reason: This refers back to 3:6. Timothy had told Paul and his companions the good news about the Thessalonians (3:6), and For this reason, they felt encouraged despite their troubles.

brothers: See the note on 1:4.

our distress and persecution: The Greek words *anagkē* (distress) and *thlipsis* (persecution) mean almost the same thing. If you do not have two similar words to use here, one way you could combine the words in your translation would be to say: “we suffer much because people are persecuting us.” It seems that people were persecuting Paul and his companions in Corinth, where he was when he wrote this letter.

persecution: The Greek word *thlipsis*, which the BSB translates as persecution here, is the same word that was translated as “suffering” in 1:6c and “trials” in 3:3a.

3:7b

we have been reassured about you, because of your faith.

- we^(excl) have become encouraged about you, because we^(excl) heard that you are still trusting in Christ.

we have been reassured about you: What encouraged them was the good news that the Thessalonians were continuing to believe in Christ. Here is another way to translate this clause:

we were encouraged about you (NIV)

1 Thessalonians 3:8

Section 3:6–13: Timothy had visited the Thessalonians and brought Paul an encouraging report

Paragraph 3:6–10

Timothy had returned from Thessalonica with the good news that the Thessalonians still affectionately remembered Paul and his companions and that they still trusted in God and loved other people. This encouraged Paul greatly. The news made him pray even more fervently that he and his companions might be able to visit the Thessalonians again.

3:8

In this verse Paul told the Thessalonians more specifically why he was encouraged.

3:8a

For now we can go on living,

- And now we^(excl) can enjoy living again,
- And now life is worthwhile for us^(excl),

now we can go on living: This is an idiomatic use of the verb “to live.” The Greek text reads literally “we live.” The BSB has translated this as go on living to make the sense clear in English. Some English versions use other idioms to express the meaning. For example:

we can breathe again (NJB)

During the time when Paul was worried about the Thessalonians, his life was affected negatively because he was anxious. Once he knew that things were well with the Thessalonians, he was relieved, joyful, could enjoy life again, and had everything that made life worthwhile. It is difficult to find a short, non-idiomatic expression in English to express all of this meaning. If you have an idiom in your language that expresses this meaning, you could use it here.

3:8b

as long as you are standing firm in the Lord.

- since we^(excl) know you are firmly believing in the Lord Jesus.
- as long as you continue to firmly believe in the Lord Jesus.

as long as you are standing firm: The Greek is literally “if you are standing firm” (RSV, KJV, GNT, NET, NCV, SSA). This may have the following meanings:

1. Paul could “go on living” because he was sure that they were standing firm. (REB, NJB, CEV, NLT, NIV)
2. Paul could “go on living” only if they were standing firm. (BSB, GW)

It is recommended that you follow the first meaning (1). Most commentators agree that the “if” does not mean that Paul doubted whether the Thessalonians were standing firm.

standing firm in the Lord: This expressions means “continuing to believe strongly in the Lord.”

the Lord: This refers to the Lord Jesus.

1 Thessalonians 3:9

Section 3:6–13: Timothy had visited the Thessalonians and brought Paul an encouraging report

Paragraph 3:6–10

Timothy had returned from Thessalonica with the good news that the Thessalonians still affectionately remembered Paul and his companions and that they still trusted in God and loved other people. This encouraged Paul greatly. The news made him pray even more fervently that he and his companions might be able to visit the Thessalonians again.

3:9a

How can we adequately thank God for you

- We^(excl) can never thank God enough

How can we adequately thank God for you: This is the beginning of a rhetorical question that in Greek continues to the end of 3:10. What Paul was really saying was: “We cannot adequately thank God for you.” It is an emphatic statement. Translate it as a rhetorical question only if it is natural in your language and if it will convey the correct meaning.

3:9b

in return for our great joy over you in His presence?

- when we^(excl) pray, because you have caused/brought us^(excl) so much joy.
- when we^(excl) come into God’s presence to pray, because of the way you have caused us to rejoice.

in return for our great joy over you: By continuing to believe firmly in Christ, the Thessalonians had caused Paul to rejoice.

in His presence: When Paul prayed, he considered that God was present.

1 Thessalonians 3:10

Section 3:6–13: Timothy had visited the Thessalonians and brought Paul an encouraging report

Paragraph 3:6–10

Timothy had returned from Thessalonica with the good news that the Thessalonians still affectionately remembered Paul and his companions and that they still trusted in God and loved other people. This encouraged Paul greatly. The news made him pray even more fervently that he and his companions might be able to visit the Thessalonians again.

3:10a

Night and day we pray most earnestly that we may see you face to face

- As we^(excl) pray and thank God, we^(excl) pray fervently night and day, that we may be able to visit you again.
- When we^(excl) pray and thank God, we^(excl) pray very earnestly that God will enable us^(excl) to visit you again.

Night and day we pray most earnestly that we may see you face to face: This verse does not begin a new sentence in Greek. Paul was saying that he and his companions rejoiced in God's presence as they prayed night and day. It may be natural in your language not to begin a new sentence in this verse. For example:

⁹For what thanksgiving can we return to God for you, for all the joy that we feel for your sake before our God, ¹⁰as we pray most earnestly night and day that we may see you face to face and supply what is lacking in your faith? (ESV)

Night and day: See the note on 2:9b.

face to face: See the notes on 2:17b and 2:17c.

3:10b

and supply what is lacking from your faith.

- And that when we^(excl) visit you again, we^(excl) will be able to teach you what is necessary so that you may believe in the Lord Jesus Christ fully/completely.
- And that when we^(excl) visit you again, we^(excl) will be able to help you to believe more strongly in the Lord Jesus Christ.

and supply what is lacking from your faith: Paul and his companions had only been able to spend a short time in Thessalonica. Therefore, Paul felt that he still had much to teach them about their Christian faith. Although the rest of this letter adds some of that teaching, as does 2 Thessalonians, Paul still prayed that he would be able to teach them again in person one day.

your faith: This refers to what the Thessalonians believed concerning God and Christ.

1 Thessalonians 3:11

Section 3:6–13: Timothy had visited the Thessalonians and brought Paul an encouraging report

Paragraph 3:11–13

So Paul prayed that God would make it possible for him and his companions to return to Thessalonica. He also prayed that God would help the Thessalonian believers to love one another better and trust the Lord Jesus more strongly.

3:11

Now may our God and Father Himself, and our Lord Jesus, direct our way to you.

- ¶! Now we^(excl) pray to our^(incl) God who is our^(incl) Father and to our^(incl) Lord Jesus to ask them to prepare the way so that we^(excl) may come to visit you again.
- ¶! Now we^(excl) pray to God our^(incl) Father and to our^(incl) Lord Jesus and ask them to remove whatever hinders us^(excl) from coming to visit you again.

Paul sometimes added a prayer at the end of a section or a complete letter. See 1 Thessalonians 5:23; 2 Thessalonians 2:16, 3:16.

Now: This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that the BSB, like most English versions, translates as Now to show that Paul is making a transition. Be careful not to translate this conjunction literally as a time word, as it is not referring to “the present time.”

our God and Father: See the note on 1:3a.

Himself: The Greek word *autos*, which the BSB translates as Himself, is often used to emphasize something. However, that is not true in this verse. It is just the usual opening for a prayer in Greek that asks God to do something for someone.

direct our way to you: The Greek word *kateuthunō*, which the BSB has translated as direct, means “make straight, guide correctly.” Therefore, there are two ways to understand what it means here:

1. It means “make straight.” So Paul was asking God to remove anything that would hinder or delay him

returning to Thessalonica, just as someone would remove obstacles on a path or smooth out the surface of a road. (NIV, GNT, NCV, NJB, REB)

2. It means “guide well/correctly.” So Paul was asking God to direct him and his companions safely and directly back to the Thessalonians. (BSB, KJV, RSV, NET, GW)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1), as it makes good sense in the context of 2:18, where Paul wrote that Satan had hindered him from returning to Thessalonica. It would therefore be logical for Paul to ask God to remove such a hindrance.

1 Thessalonians 3:12

Section 3:6–13: Timothy had visited the Thessalonians and brought Paul an encouraging report

Paragraph 3:11–13

So Paul prayed that God would make it possible for him and his companions to return to Thessalonica. He also prayed that God would help the Thessalonian believers to love one another better and trust the Lord Jesus more strongly.

3:12a

And may the Lord cause you to increase and overflow with love for one another and for everyone else,

- We^(excl) also pray that the Lord Jesus will cause your love for one another and everyone else to increase so that it becomes greater,
- We^(excl) also pray that the Lord Jesus will cause you to love one another and everyone else more and more,

Here, and in 3:13, Paul prayed for the Thessalonians.

the Lord: This refers to the Lord Jesus.

cause you to increase and overflow with love:

The Greek verbs *pleonazō*, which the BSB translates as *cause...to increase*, and *perisseuō*, which the BSB translates as *cause...to...overflow*, mean almost the same thing. The second verb emphasizes the first one. The BSB has used a metaphor here that means in this context, “May God help you to increasingly love others, like someone filling a cup with water until it is full and it overflows.”

3:12b

just as our love for you overflows,

- in the same way that our^(excl) love for you is increasing and is becoming greater.

just as our love for you overflows: In Greek, this part of the verse literally says “and we to you.” Some words are implied here that may need to be made explicit

in your translation, as in the BSB. Paul was probably asking the Lord to increase the Thessalonians’ love for others in the same way that the love of Paul and his companions for the Thessalonians was increasing.

1 Thessalonians 3:13

Section 3:6–13: Timothy had visited the Thessalonians and brought Paul an encouraging report

Paragraph 3:11–13

So Paul prayed that God would make it possible for him and his companions to return to Thessalonica. He also prayed that God would help the Thessalonian believers to love one another better and trust the Lord Jesus more strongly.

3:13a

so that He may establish your hearts

- We^(excl) pray this so that the Lord Jesus will strengthen you spiritually
- We^(excl) pray this so that the Lord Jesus will help you to trust him more strongly

so that He may establish your hearts: This part of the verse states the purpose of 3:12a. One way to make this connection clear would be to begin the verse:

We (excl) pray this so that He may establish your hearts

He may establish your hearts: The verb that the BSB translates as *establish* is the same verb that Paul used in 3:2b. The expression *your hearts* refers to the inner being—the thoughts, feelings, and purposes of a person (see the note on 2:4c). Paul was therefore asking God to strengthen the Thessalonians inwardly so they would do what pleased God.

3:13b

in blamelessness and holiness before our God and Father

- so that God our^(incl) Father will not accuse you of any sin when you meet him and you will be pleasing to him

blamelessness: The word *blamelessness* here means “God will not accuse you of doing wrong.” See the note on 2:10b

holiness: See the note on “holy” in 2:10b. Although Paul used a different word here, the meaning is the same in this context. See *holy* in the glossary, meaning 2.

our God and Father: See the note on 1:3a.

3:13c

at the coming of our Lord Jesus with all His saints. Amen.

- when our^(incl) Lord Jesus returns to earth accompanied by all his holy ones.

at the coming of our Lord Jesus with all His saints:

This refers to the time when Jesus will return to earth to judge everyone.

His saints: In this context, commentators do not agree about how the Greek word *hagioi*, which the BSB translates as saints, should be translated. There are two possibilities:

1. It refers to angels. If Paul is alluding to the Old Testament sense of “holy ones,” this would be the meaning.
2. It refers to Christians, whom Paul often refers to as “saints.” This is how most English versions translate it.

These are both possible. Some English versions use a phrase that could include both meanings. For example:

all those who belong to him (GNT)

If you decide to use a term in your translation that only means “angels” or that only means “Christians,” then it would be a good idea to include the other possibility in a footnote.

1 Thessalonians 4:1

Section 4:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians how to behave in a way that would please God

Paragraph 4:1–8

Paul reminded the Thessalonian believers that he had already taught them how to behave in order to please God. He then urged them to do even better than they had done already.

4:1a

Finally, brothers, we ask and encourage you in the Lord Jesus to live in a way that is pleasing to God,

- ¶ Furthermore, brothers, we^(excl) ask you, indeed we^(excl) urge you, as fellow believers in the Lord Jesus, that you should behave in order to please God,

Finally: The Greek word *loipon*, which the BSB translates as Finally, indicates that here Paul was beginning the second and last major part of his letter. As in many of his other letters, in this final part he instructs the Thessalonians about how Christians should behave. However, remember there are still two

chapters left, so avoid using a term which would make it sound like Paul was ending his letter here.

In Greek, the verse begins with *oun*, “therefore.” Paul used this term to indicate that what he was about to write in chapters 4 and 5 was based on what he wrote in the first part of the letter, that is, chapters 1–3.

brothers: See the note on 1:4.

we ask and encourage you: The commentators disagree about whether there is any significant difference between the meaning of the two Greek verbs *erōtaō* (ask) and *parakaleō* (encourage). Paul often used two verbs instead of one with the second one emphasizing the first. In your translation you have a choice about how to translate these two verbs:

- Use two verbs with similar meaning. This is what almost every English version has done.
- Combine the two verbs into one expression, for example, “we strongly urge you.”

You should retain two verbs if it is possible to do so in your language. Otherwise, you can follow the second option.

in the Lord Jesus: This is a phrase that Paul often used in his letters. However, commentators disagree about what it means. The same expression is used in 2 Thessalonians 3:12. There are two possible meanings:

1. It means “because we are united in Christ Jesus.” Paul was appealing to the common fellowship that he, his companions, and the Thessalonians had because they were all members of the family of God. (REB, CEV, SSA)
2. It means “because the Lord Jesus has authorized us.” This interpretation seems to be supported by the phrase “by the authority of the Lord Jesus” in 4:2. (GNT, KJV, GW, NLT)

Other English versions do not clearly indicate which of these interpretations they follow. However, it is recommended that you follow the first option (1), because in the context of this letter, Paul was emphasizing the Thessalonians’ love for him and God and Jesus, rather than his authority as an apostle.

4:1b

just as you have received from us.

- which we^(excl) already taught you when we^(excl) were with you.

just as you have received from us: Paul was referring to instructions that he and his companions had given the Thessalonian believers while they were with them. He was not referring to the instructions in the previous part of this letter. Paul and his companions

had already taught them how to behave as a Christian should.

4:1c

This is how you already live,

- This is indeed the way you are behaving now.

This is how you already live: This clause is omitted in KJV because some Greek manuscripts omit it. But the UBS Greek text and other major English versions agree that it should be there. Therefore, you should include it in your translation. As he did in 1:6–9, Paul was recognizing that the Thessalonians were already behaving in the way he had mentioned in 4:1a.

4:1d

so you should do so all the more.

- Even though we^(excl) know that you are doing this, you should please God more and more.

so you should do so all the more: This means “you should please God all the more.” Paul was never content that those whom he had helped to believe in Christ should do the minimum to prove they were Christians. He wanted them all to imitate Jesus as much as possible.

1 Thessalonians 4:2

Section 4:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians how to behave in a way that would please God

Paragraph 4:1–8

Paul reminded the Thessalonian believers that he had already taught them how to behave in order to please God. He then urged them to do even better than they had done already.

4:2

For you know the instructions we gave you by the authority of the Lord Jesus.

- We^(excl) urge you to do this because you already know what the Lord Jesus authorized us^(excl) to teach you while we^(excl) were with you.

For you know the instructions we gave you: This verse gives Paul’s reason for what he told the Thessalonians to do in 4:1c. That is, these were not new instructions, but ones he had already given them when he was in Thessalonica.

by the authority of the Lord Jesus: The commentators agree that this relates to the fact that Jesus had authorized Paul and his companions to teach people.

1 Thessalonians 4:3

Section 4:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians how to behave in a way that would please God

Paragraph 4:1–8

Paul reminded the Thessalonian believers that he had already taught them how to behave in order to please God. He then urged them to do even better than they had done already.

4:3

Verses 4:3–6 are one sentence in the Greek text. You will probably need to use several sentences in your translation, as many English versions have done. All four verses, however, deal with the same topic, that is, instructions to avoid being sexually immoral.

4:3a

For it is God’s will that you should be holy:

- What God wants is that you should behave purely/righteously,
- What God wants is that you should become holy,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For shows that what Paul was about to give was a specific example of what he had instructed them while he was in Thessalonica. Many English versions have chosen to leave this conjunction implied. Introduce this verse in a natural way in your language.

that you should be holy: To be holy means “to be sanctified” or “to be set apart for God.” Most commentators agree that in this verse Paul was referring to “becoming sanctified/holy” rather than “being set apart for God.” See sanctify in KBT under the term “holy” and in the glossary under sanctify, meaning 2.

4:3b

You must abstain from sexual immorality;

- which means that you should never commit any kind of sexual immorality.
- which means that you should never sin sexually.

You must abstain from sexual immorality: Here Paul gave one specific example of morally impure behavior. The Greek word porneia, which the BSB translates as sexual immorality, is a general term that means any kind of sexual immorality, that is, any kind of sexual act other than that between a man and his wife.

1 Thessalonians 4:4

Section 4:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians how to behave in a way that would please God

Paragraph 4:1–8

Paul reminded the Thessalonian believers that he had already taught them how to behave in order to please

God. He then urged them to do even better than they had done already.

4:4a **each of you must know how to control his own body**

- In particular, each of you should learn to control his body/sexual-desires

to control his own body: The Greek word *skeuos*, which the BSB translates as body, literally means “vessel, implement of any kind.” In this verse it is used in a figurative way. However, commentators do not agree what the word means here. There are two possible meanings:

1. It means “body.” If this is the case, Paul was telling people to be self-controlled, in particular, to control their sexual desires. If a person does so, he is being pure and honorable. Most commentators agree with this meaning. (BSB, NIV, NCV, NLT, NRSV, REB, NJB)
2. It means “wife.” If this is the case, then Paul meant that men should learn the right way to acquire a wife or behave toward a wife. (RSV, GNT, NET, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1), as it makes best sense in the context, where Paul was talking about avoiding sexual immorality (4:3b) and lust (4:5a).

4:4b **in holiness and honor,**

- in a way that is pure and worthy of honour/respect.
- in a way that is pure and that people would praise/respect.

holiness: For holiness, see the note on 2:10b. See also holy in the glossary, meaning 2.

honor: To behave with honor means to behave in a way that will cause someone to praise/respect you. In this verse, Paul did not state whose respect or praise was wanted. If you need to specify this, it is probably best to say “in a way that would cause people to honor/respect you.”

1 Thessalonians 4:5

Section 4:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians how to behave in a way that would please God

Paragraph 4:1–8

Paul reminded the Thessalonian believers that he had already taught them how to behave in order to please God. He then urged them to do even better than they had done already.

4:5a **not in lustful passion**

- Do not let yourselves be controlled by a desire for sexual intercourse

not in lustful passion: The phrase lustful passion refers to the opposite of self-control. It refers to someone strongly desiring to have sexual intercourse with someone else, whether or not that person is their spouse.

4:5b **like the Gentiles who do not know God;**

- like people who do not worship God,

like the Gentiles who do not know God: The Greek word *ethnē*, which the BSB, KJV, and NRSV translate as Gentiles, is sometimes translated “heathen” (NIV, RSV, GNT). It is normally used by Jews to refer to those who are not Jews, those who do not worship the one true God. People who do not know God cannot behave in ways that please him. See “gentiles”, sense 2 in KBT and in the glossary.

1 Thessalonians 4:6

Section 4:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians how to behave in a way that would please God

Paragraph 4:1–8

Paul reminded the Thessalonian believers that he had already taught them how to behave in order to please God. He then urged them to do even better than they had done already.

4:6a **and no one should ever violate or exploit his brother in this regard,**

- and you should not sin against your brother or cheat him by have sexual intercourse with his wife.

no one should ever violate or exploit his brother: The implied information in this part of the verse is “by having sexual intercourse with his brother’s wife.”

violate...his brother: That is, “sin against his brother.”

exploit his brother: If a man has intercourse with the wife of another man, he is doing wrong, and he is also cheating that man by taking something that belongs to him.

his brother: Paul was focusing here on sinning against fellow Christians. See the note on 1:4.

in this regard: This is literally “in the matter.” Commentators do not agree about what Paul was referring to here. There are two possibilities:

1. It refers to what Paul had already been discussing, that is, sexual immorality.
2. It refers to a new subject, that of business dealings.

Nearly all English versions follow the first option (as is shown by translations like “in this regard,” which in English clearly refer to what Paul had just been discussing). Therefore it is recommended that you also follow the first option (1).

4:6b

because the Lord will avenge all such acts, as we have already told you and solemnly warned you.

- As we^(excl) already warned you very strongly when we^(excl) were with you, the Lord Jesus will punish those who do all such things.

because the Lord will avenge all such acts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as because indicates that what Paul was about to say was a reason for obeying what he commanded in 4:3b–6a.

the Lord: This refers to the Lord Jesus.

as we have already told you and solemnly warned you: Paul was referring once more to what he and his companions had taught the Thessalonians while he was in Thessalonica.

1 Thessalonians 4:7

Section 4:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians how to behave in a way that would please God

Paragraph 4:1–8

Paul reminded the Thessalonian believers that he had already taught them how to behave in order to please God. He then urged them to do even better than they had done already.

4:7a

For God has not called us

- God wants you to obey these instructions, because, when he called us^(incl) to follow him,

For: In this verse Paul gave a second reason for what he said in 4:3b–6a. You could translate this connection by saying “God wants this because...”

God has not called us: See the note on 2:12b. The New Testament teaches that when a person becomes a Christian, God has called that person to follow him.

us: This refers to all Christians, not just Paul and his companions.

4:7b

to impurity, but to holiness.

- it was not to be sexually immoral, but he wanted us^(incl) to behave in a morally pure way.

but to holiness: God has a purpose in calling people to follow him. It is so that they may behave in a manner that is morally pure and so that they may obey his commands.

1 Thessalonians 4:8

Section 4:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians how to behave in a way that would please God

Paragraph 4:1–8

Paul reminded the Thessalonian believers that he had already taught them how to behave in order to please God. He then urged them to do even better than they had done already.

4:8a

Anyone, then, who rejects this command does not reject man but God,

- Therefore, if anyone rejects what we^(excl) instruct here, he is not just rejecting what human beings teach, but he is rejecting what God commands.

then: The Greek word *toigaroun*, which the BSB translates as then, indicates that this is Paul’s conclusion to 4:3–7. Here is another way to translate this transition word:

Therefore (NIV)

does not reject man but God: Paul was emphasizing that what he was telling the Thessalonians here was not something that he or anyone else had invented. It was something that God had revealed to him.

4:8b

the very One who gives you His Holy Spirit.

- And God is the one who gives you his Holy Spirit.

who gives you His Holy Spirit: Paul’s point was that the Thessalonians must behave in a holy manner, since God had put his Holy Spirit in them. His Spirit is holy/pure, so they too must be holy/pure. If relative clauses are only used in your language to identify something or someone, using a relative clause here would suggest that Paul was just identifying which God gives the Holy Spirit. In that case, you will have to use another grammatical construction to provide this extra information about God. One way to do this would be to use a separate sentence, as the Display has done.

1 Thessalonians 4:9

Section 4:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians how to behave in a way that would please God

Paragraph 4:9–12

God had enabled the Thessalonians to love one another. Paul urged them to do so even more and also to behave in an orderly manner. Even non-believers would respect them when they behaved like that.

4:9a

Now about brotherly love, you do not need anyone to write to you,

- ¶ Concerning how you should love one another as members of God's family, it is not necessary that we^(excl) write anything more to you,
- ¶ Now we^(excl) do not need to write anything more to you on the subject of how you should love your brothers in God's family,

Now: Here Paul began a new paragraph and told the Thessalonians why they needed to behave in a righteous manner. After warning them how not to behave in 4:3–8, he began to tell them how they should behave. The BSB has used the word *Now* to signal that this is a new paragraph. Be careful not to translate it literally as a time word. Instead, use whatever construction is natural in your language for a new paragraph.

about brotherly love: This means love for other believers.

4:9b

because you yourselves have been taught by God to love one another.

- because it was God himself who taught you to love one another.

because: In this part of the verse Paul told the Thessalonians why he had no need to write about loving each other (4:9a). It was because God himself had taught them about this love.

you yourselves have been taught by God to love one another: Paul did not say how God taught the Thessalonians to love one another. It may have been by the Holy Spirit or by Jesus' teaching. The important thing was that the teaching ultimately came from God himself.

you yourselves: In Greek, the word that the BSB translates as *yourselves* is an emphatic pronoun. If you have emphatic pronouns in your language, you should use one here.

1 Thessalonians 4:10

Section 4:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians how to behave in a way that would please God

Paragraph 4:9–12

God had enabled the Thessalonians to love one another. Paul urged them to do so even more and also to behave in an orderly manner. Even non-believers would respect them when they behaved like that.

4:10a

And you are indeed showing this love to all the brothers throughout Macedonia.

- And indeed you love all your brothers who are everywhere in the province of Macedonia.

all the brothers throughout Macedonia: Paul here expanded what he was saying to include not only believers in Thessalonica but also in Philippi and Berea and any other town in the region of Macedonia.

brothers: See the note on 1:4.

4:10b

But we urge you, brothers, to excel more and more

- However, brothers, we^(excl) urge you to love one another increasingly.

But: Paul knew that the Thessalonians already loved their fellow Christians, but he wanted them to do so even more.

we urge you: This is the same verb that the BSB translated as "encourage" in 2:12a and 3:2b and in 4:1a. See the notes on those verses.

brothers: See the note on 1:4.

to excel more and more: This phrase means "to continue to love your fellow believers more and more."

1 Thessalonians 4:11

Section 4:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians how to behave in a way that would please God

Paragraph 4:9–12

God had enabled the Thessalonians to love one another. Paul urged them to do so even more and also to behave in an orderly manner. Even non-believers would respect them when they behaved like that.

4:11a

and to aspire to live quietly,

- And we^(excl) also urge you to try earnestly to behave in a way that will not trouble others,

and to aspire to live quietly: In the Greek text, as in the BSB, this is not a new sentence. It is the second

thing that Paul was urging the Thessalonians to do. If it would be helpful to begin a new sentence here, you could make the connection with 4:10b clearer by beginning the verse with “We also urge you to...”

to aspire: This means “to try hard to do something, to do your best to do something.” Use whatever verb is most natural and forceful to translate this.

to live quietly: Another way to say to live quietly is to say “avoid causing trouble for other people.”

4:11b

to attend to your own matters,

- and not to interfere/meddle with what concerns other people and does not concern you,

to attend to your own matters: Paul was not saying that the Thessalonians should not help one another. He was saying that they should not gossip and meddle in other people’s affairs. It is possible that this part of the verse is a restatement of 4:11a. But most English versions treat it as a second item in the list of things Paul was instructing, and it is recommended that you do the same.

4:11c

and to work with your own hands,

- but to work to support yourselves.

and to work with your own hands: Paul was not telling the Thessalonians specifically to do manual work. He was really telling them not to be lazy. He wanted them to work in order to get money or food to support themselves and their families. They should not expect their fellow believers to care for them.

4:11d

as we instructed you.

- When we^(excl) were with you, we^(excl) instructed you to do all these things

as we instructed you: Paul was reminding the Thessalonians that this was not something new. It was what he had already taught them while he was in Thessalonica. He was not here referring to the instructions in this particular letter.

1 Thessalonians 4:12

Section 4:1–12: Paul reminded the Thessalonians how to behave in a way that would please God

Paragraph 4:9–12

God had enabled the Thessalonians to love one another. Paul urged them to do so even more and also to behave in an orderly manner. Even non-believers would respect them when they behaved like that.

4:12a

Then you will behave properly toward outsiders,

- so that those who do not believe will see how you behave every day and will respect you because of it

you will behave: This refers to the way the Thessalonians lived every day.

properly toward outsiders: The word outsiders refers to those who did not believe in the Lord Jesus. Not everything that believers do will please non-believers. But Paul was saying that believers must behave and work in ways that everyone recognized as the correct way to behave. For example, no one would respect a lazy person, so the believers should make sure they were not lazy.

4:12b

without being dependent on anyone.

- and so that you will not need to depend on anyone else to give you food and drink.

without being dependent on anyone: This refers back to the phrase in 4:11c, “and to work with your hands.” Those who worked would not need to ask others for food and drink. Here Paul is describing a second result that will happen if the Thessalonians behave as he told them to behave in 4:10–11. (The first result is in 4:12a.)

on anyone: The commentators do not agree about what the Greek word *mēdenos*, “nobody, nothing,” means here. There are two possibilities:

1. It means “no one.” The meaning of 4:12b therefore is “so that you will be dependent on no one”. (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NJB, GW, CEV, NCV, NLT)
2. It means “nothing.” The meaning of 4:12b therefore is “so that you may need nothing”. (KJV, REB, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1), as it fits the context better, especially 4:11c.

1 Thessalonians 4:13

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 4:13–18

While Paul was in Thessalonica, he had probably taught the Thessalonians that Jesus would soon return, and the Thessalonians may have assumed that

they would all survive until then. But as time passed, some of them died. Those who remained alive had begun to worry whether those believers who had died would see Jesus return. This is the issue Paul was addressing in this paragraph.

4:13a

Brothers, we do not want you to be uninformed about those who sleep in death,

- ¶ Brothers, we^(excl) want you to know what will happen to those believers who have died.

Brothers: See the note on 1:4.

we do not want you to be uninformed: It may be more natural in your language to translate this as a strong positive sentence. For example:

We want you to know (NCV)

We want you to be quite certain (NJB)

about those who sleep in death: Paul was not talking about actual sleep here. He was using a polite way to speak about dying. The BSB has added the words in death to make this clear. In your translation, use the common word for dying or an appropriate polite expression.

4:13b

so that you will not grieve like the rest, who are without hope.

- That way, you will not mourn the way unbelievers mourn for other unbelievers who have died because they cannot be certain that after they die they will become alive again.

so that you will not grieve like the rest, who are without hope: Paul was not saying that the relatives of a dead person should not mourn or perform a funeral. Rather, he was saying that they should not grieve in the hopeless way that unbelievers grieve. Because believers know that other believers who die will become alive again, while they may still grieve for them, they do not grieve as people do who are without hope.

like the rest: This phrase refers to unbelievers.

who are without hope: Unbelievers do not believe that they will live again on earth or that they will be with Jesus. See the note in 1:3d on the word hope. In this verse it also means “being certain.” Paul did not doubt at all that Christians would live again one day after Christ returned. It may be necessary in some lan-

guages to say what the unbelievers were not certain about. One way to make this clear would be:

who do not confidently expect to live again after they die as you believers expect to do (see SSA)

1 Thessalonians 4:14

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 4:13–18

While Paul was in Thessalonica, he had probably taught the Thessalonians that Jesus would soon return, and the Thessalonians may have assumed that they would all survive until then. But as time passed, some of them died. Those who remained alive had begun to worry whether those believers who had died would see Jesus return. This is the issue Paul was addressing in this paragraph.

4:14a

For since we believe that Jesus died and rose again,

- Do not mourn as they do, because we^(incl) believe as a fact that Jesus died and became alive again,

4:14b

we also believe that God will bring with Jesus those who have fallen asleep in Him.

- and therefore we^(incl) believe/know that when Jesus returns to earth, God will cause all those believers in Jesus who have died to come to be with Jesus.

we...believe that: These words are implied in the Greek text and may need to be made explicit in your translation.

also: This connects this part of the verse back to 4:14a. In 4:14a, Paul stated the basis for what he said in 4:14b. Another way to translate this connection would be:

Because we believe that Jesus died and rose again, then certainly God will bring with Jesus those who have fallen asleep with him.

God will bring with Jesus: Most English versions are ambiguous in the way they translate this part of the verse. The Greek verb *agō*, which the BSB translates as bring, is a general verb of motion and means “bring,

take, lead, go.” The commentators suggest many different ways of understanding this part of the verse. The two most likely interpretations are:

1. Paul was focusing on the fact that when Jesus returns, the bodies of Christians who have died will be resurrected. He therefore meant that God would bring these resurrected bodies from earth to be with Jesus as he returns.
2. Paul was focusing on the fact that after a Christian dies, his soul is with Jesus. He therefore meant here that God would bring these people from heaven back to earth with Jesus.

Paul did not specify which of these possibilities he was thinking of. What Paul wrote in 4:14–17 makes it clear that God will cause both the resurrected believers and the ones still living to ascend into the sky to meet Jesus as he is descending to earth. This seems to favor the first interpretation. However, Paul’s main point was that from that moment all Christians would be with Jesus, whether on earth or in heaven. So if possible, you should avoid making your translation too explicit at this point.

those who have fallen asleep: See the note on 4:13a.

in Him: In Greek, the phrase that the BSB translates as in Him could mean either “in him” or “with him.” It is not clear from the Greek word order to which verb this phrase should be connected. There are two possibilities:

1. It should be attached to the verb “fallen asleep,” which comes earlier in the sentence it in the Greek text. The majority of commentators also support this. The meaning of the phrase “those who have fallen asleep in Him” therefore is “those who were believers when they died.” (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, KJV, REB, SSA, NLT, NASB, CEV, NJB)
2. It should be attached to the verb “will bring” which directly precedes it in the Greek text. The meaning is therefore that it is “through Jesus” that God will cause believers to live again. (RSV, GW, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1), as do the majority of English versions and commentators. It is the most probable grammatically.

1 Thessalonians 4:15

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalo-

nians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 4:13–18

While Paul was in Thessalonica, he had probably taught the Thessalonians that Jesus would soon return, and the Thessalonians may have assumed that they would all survive until then. But as time passed, some of them died. Those who remained alive had begun to worry whether those believers who had died would see Jesus return. This is the issue Paul was addressing in this paragraph.

4:15a

By the word of the Lord, we declare to you

- It is what the Lord Jesus himself has said that we^(excl) are telling you:

By the word of the Lord, we declare to you: Paul explained that Jesus himself spoke the words that he was telling them. It can only be guessed which of the following Paul was referring to: (1) Sayings of Jesus that had been written down, and which were later included in the Gospels. Matthew 24:30–31 is an example. (2) A message from Jesus received directly by Paul. (3) “Sayings of Jesus” which were recorded by someone, but which were not included in the Gospels. The problem is that not everything Paul taught in these verses is found in the Gospels in their present form. So it must be that Paul learned from both sources (1) and (2). See the discussion on this in Best, pp. 189–193. However, we do not know when Jesus said this or to whom. Therefore, you should not be specific in your translation. If you must say to whom Jesus said this, use as general a term as possible, for example, “according to what the Lord said to people.”

4:15b

that we who are alive and remain until the coming of the Lord

- we^(incl) who are still alive when the Lord Jesus returns

that we who are alive and remain until the coming of the Lord: This refers to any believer who was alive at the time when Paul was writing and therefore who might still be alive when Jesus returned.

4:15c

will by no means precede those who have fallen asleep.

- will certainly not meet him before those believers who have already died.

will by no means precede those who have fallen asleep: The BSB phrase by no means translates two different Greek words that both mean “not.” When both occur together, they make the sentence an em-

phatic negative. Paul was emphasizing that believers who had died would certainly not get left behind when the Lord returned. This was what the Thessalonians had been worrying about.

precede: This means that believers who are alive when Jesus returns will not meet Jesus before those who have already died.

those who have fallen asleep: See the note on 4:13a.

1 Thessalonians 4:16

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 4:13–18

While Paul was in Thessalonica, he had probably taught the Thessalonians that Jesus would soon return, and the Thessalonians may have assumed that they would all survive until then. But as time passed, some of them died. Those who remained alive had begun to worry whether those believers who had died would see Jesus return. This is the issue Paul was addressing in this paragraph.

4:16a

For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven

- In fact, what will happen is that the Lord Jesus himself will come down from heaven

For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven: The Lord Jesus is presently sitting at God's right hand in heaven. See, for example, Luke 22:69; Acts 7:55. It is from there that he will descend to earth.

the Lord Himself: The Lord Jesus Christ will personally return to earth.

4:16b–d

with a loud command, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God: Commentators disagree about whether this part of the verse describes three events, two events, or one event. However, the Greek text lists them as three events, and most English versions translate them in that way, so it is recommended that you also translate them as three distinct events.

4:16b

with a loud command,

- and will shout a command,

- and people will hear him shout a command.

with a loud command: Most scholars agree that this refers to a command that Jesus himself will shout. If possible, do not state what or whom Jesus commands. Paul did not tell us, and so we can only guess. If it is necessary to include this information in your translation, you could translate it:

he will loudly command believers who have died to become alive again

4:16c

with the voice of an archangel,

- and one of God's chief angels will speak loudly,
- People will hear an archangel speak

with the voice of an archangel: People will also hear an archangel speak. He may be speaking to other angels, but we do not know this.

an archangel: An archangel is a chief angel.

4:16d

and with the trumpet of God,

- and God's trumpet will be blown.
- and they will hear an angel blow God's trumpet.

with the trumpet of God: This does not mean that God will blow the trumpet, but that the trumpet belongs to God. Paul did not tell us here who will blow the trumpet. However, in Revelation, it is always angels who blow trumpets to announce events. See, for example, Revelation 8–11. If it is possible in your language, do not say who blows the trumpet, but that "God's trumpet will be blown." If it is necessary to indicate who blows the trumpet, you could say "an angel."

4:16e

and the dead in Christ will be the first to rise.

- Then, first of all, those believers in Christ who have died will become alive again.

the dead in Christ: Most English versions understand this to refer to those who believed in Christ before they died, that is, "believers who have died."

will be the first to rise: This means that the believers who have already died will become alive again, before those who are still living go to meet Christ in the air. It does not mean that those who have died will rise into the air before those who are still living.

1 Thessalonians 4:17

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 4:13–18

While Paul was in Thessalonica, he had probably taught the Thessalonians that Jesus would soon return, and the Thessalonians may have assumed that they would all survive until then. But as time passed, some of them died. Those who remained alive had begun to worry whether those believers who had died would see Jesus return. This is the issue Paul was addressing in this paragraph.

4:17a

After that, we who are alive and remain will be caught up together with them in the clouds

- After that. God will gather them together with those of us^(incl) who are still alive and lift us^(incl) all up into the clouds

we who are alive and remain: See the note on 4:15b.

will be caught up together with them: All the believers, both those who are still alive and those who have just become alive again, will suddenly be lifted up and taken upward from the earth into the sky to meet Jesus as he descends from heaven. If you need to say who lifts the believers, you should say it is God.

them: This refers back to “the dead in Christ” (4:16e).

in the clouds: In the Scriptures, the Messiah’s (Christ’s) coming is sometimes mentioned together with the phrase “with clouds” (Daniel 7:13; Matthew 24:30, 26:64; Mark 13:26, 14:62; Revelation 1:7).

4:17b

to meet the Lord in the air.

- to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky.

in the air: The phrase in the air probably refers to the same place as “in the clouds.” Here is another way to translate this phrase:

in the sky (CEV)

4:17c

And so we will always be with the Lord.

- From that time we^(incl) will remain with the Lord Jesus for ever.

And so we will always be with the Lord: From the time that Jesus returns, believers will never again be physically separated from him.

1 Thessalonians 4:18

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 4:13–18

While Paul was in Thessalonica, he had probably taught the Thessalonians that Jesus would soon return, and the Thessalonians may have assumed that they would all survive until then. But as time passed, some of them died. Those who remained alive had begun to worry whether those believers who had died would see Jesus return. This is the issue Paul was addressing in this paragraph.

4:18

Therefore encourage one another with these words.

- So continually encourage one another by reminding each other about what I have just said.

Therefore: This word indicates that this verse is Paul’s final remark on this subject he discussed in 4:14–17. Here is another way to translate this word:

Because all this is true

encourage one another: The form of the Greek verb *parakaleō*, which the BSB translates as encourage, indicates a continuing action. So it is best translated as “continue encouraging” or “continually encourage.”

with these words: This refers to the whole message of 4:14–17. Paul was not telling the Thessalonians to repeat these words exactly to one another, but to remind each other about what he had said in 4:14–17, that is, that all believers, whether they had already died or were still alive when Christ returned, would meet him together.

1 Thessalonians 5:1

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 5:1–3

Paul reminded the Thessalonians that no one can know when Jesus will return. When unbelievers think that all is well, Jesus will come suddenly, and they will not be able to escape being judged and punished by him.

5:1

Now about the times and seasons, brothers, we do not need to write to you.

- ¶ Brothers, it is not necessary for us^(excl) to write and tell you the time when the Lord Jesus will return.

Now: This is the start of a new paragraph. Here Paul answered another question the Thessalonians must have asked him, about when exactly Jesus would return. As in 4:9a, the BSB has once more used the word *Now* to signal a new paragraph. Read the note on 4:9a for advice on how to translate this word.

about the times and seasons: When the Greek words *chronoi* (times) and *kairoi* (seasons) occur together in Scripture, it is often when people are speaking about future events. For an example, see Acts 1:7. There are two possible ways to understand these words here:

1. There is no real difference in meaning between the two words, and the whole expression is an idiom for “the day of the Lord” (see 5:2b).
2. There is a difference between the two words. The word *chronoi* (times) refers to “duration of time.” The word *kairoi* (seasons) refers to “the significant events that happen before Jesus will return.” Here is one way to translate this possible sense of the expression:

times and occasions (GNT)

It is not easy to decide between these two opinions. However, in this passage Paul’s main subject was “the day of the Lord.” So it is logical to assume that here he was referring to the time when the day of the Lord would occur. It is therefore recommended that you follow the first option (1).

brothers: See the note on 1:4.

1 Thessalonians 5:2

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 5:1–3

Paul reminded the Thessalonians that no one can know when Jesus will return. When unbelievers think that all is well, Jesus will come suddenly, and they will not be able to escape being judged and punished by him.

5:2a

For you are fully aware

- We^(excl) say this because you know well

For you are fully aware: Paul had undoubtedly told the Thessalonians about these things when he was with them, but here he reminded them they could not know the exact day and time when Jesus would return.

5:2b

that the Day of the Lord will come like a thief in the night.

- that the day when the Lord Jesus will come again will be unexpected like a thief who comes unexpectedly in the night while the houseowner is asleep.

the Day of the Lord will come like a thief in the night: This whole sentence is a simile. Paul was not comparing Jesus to a thief who steals something.

The point of the comparison is that Jesus will return unexpectedly, at a time when people are not prepared, in the same way that a thief comes during the night when people are asleep and not expecting him. Jesus himself taught similarly in Matthew 24:43. One way to express this would be:

the Lord will come as unexpectedly as a thief who comes at night (UBS handbook, p106).

the Day of the Lord: The phrase the Day of the Lord was a well-known phrase in the OT (for example, see Joel 2:31; Amos 5:18; Malachi 4:5). When this phrase occurred in the OT, “Lord” always referred to God the Father. The whole phrase therefore referred to the time when God would judge the people of the world and punish those who had sinned against him. However, in the NT, the Lord almost always refers to the

Lord Jesus. So the Day of the Lord here means “the day when the Lord Jesus will return to earth.”

will come: In some languages it may not be possible to say that a day/time will come. If this is the case in your language, you may need to talk about Jesus himself coming.

1 Thessalonians 5:3

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 5:1–3

Paul reminded the Thessalonians that no one can know when Jesus will return. When unbelievers think that all is well, Jesus will come suddenly, and they will not be able to escape being judged and punished by him.

5:3a

While people are saying, “Peace and security,”

- When people are saying that the world is peaceful and safe,
- While people are saying, “There is no war and we^(incl) are not in any danger,”

While people are saying, “Peace and security”: Paul may have been remembering the words of Jeremiah 6:14:

saying, ‘Peace, peace,’ when there is no peace at all.

See also Ezekiel 13:10.

Peace: This probably refers to no war, fighting, or quarreling.

security: This probably refers to a time when there is no danger, a time when people can live without being afraid. It therefore overlaps in meaning with “peace.”

5:3b

destruction will come upon them suddenly, like labor pains on a pregnant woman,

- at that time, they will be suddenly ruined. It will happen as suddenly as labour pains begin for a pregnant woman.

- that is the time when they will suddenly experience very great trouble. The trouble will begin just as suddenly as a pregnant woman’s labour pains begin.

destruction will come upon them suddenly: The Greek word *olethros*, which the BSB translates as destruction, does not mean the people will no longer exist. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

calamity (NEB)

disaster (NLT)

See 2 Thessalonians 1:9; 1 Corinthians 5:5; 1 Timothy 6:9. If you need to use a verb here in your language instead of a noun, you could translate this:

suddenly they will lose everything

suddenly they will be ruined

them: This refers to the people in 5:3a who had been saying that everything was peaceful and secure.

like labor pains on a pregnant woman: The phrase labor pains refers to the pains that a pregnant woman suffers when she is about to give birth. These pains begin suddenly, and that is the point of the comparison here, that destruction will come suddenly, just as a woman’s labor pains start suddenly.

5:3c

and they will not escape.

- And they will not be able to escape that very great trouble.
- They will definitely not have time to escape that disaster.

they will not escape: The coming destruction is not only sudden, it is also certain to come, just as a pregnant woman is certain to suffer labor pains. Those who are not prepared for Jesus’ return will not be able to escape God’s judgment.

1 Thessalonians 5:4

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 5:4–11

Because the Lord will return suddenly but people do not know when this will happen, Paul told the believers at Thessalonica that they should be prepared for the Lord Jesus to return at any time.

5:4–8

In these verses Paul used a series of metaphors, including darkness and light, night and day, asleep and awake, drunk and sober. These metaphors are related to one another, yet they contrast with one another.

5:4a

But you, brothers, are not in the darkness

- ¶ But you, my friends, are not living in the darkness.
- ¶ But you, brothers, do not belong to this evil world, which is like being in darkness.

brothers: See the note on 1:4.

are not in the darkness: The metaphor of darkness in 5:4 is the opposite of the metaphors of “light” and “day” in 5:5a. “Darkness” (and “night” in 5:5b) in the Bible is a metaphor for evil. When a person becomes a Christian, he leaves the darkness of sin and Satan and enters God’s kingdom of light. See, for example, Ephesians 5:8; Colossians 1:13; 1 Peter 2:9.

If the metaphor of darkness referring to evil and of light referring to goodness and purity can be understood in your language, then use it to translate these verses. If not, then try using a simile (for example, “this evil world, which is like darkness”). If that cannot be understood, translate only the meaning.

5:4b

so that this day should overtake you like a thief.

- Therefore the arrival of the day when the Lord Jesus comes will not surprise you the way a thief surprises a homeowner.

so that this day should overtake you like a thief:

This part of the verse is the result of 5:4a. Paul was saying that since the Thessalonians were no longer in darkness (and therefore unaware of what was happening), they would not be surprised or unprepared when Jesus returned.

like a thief: See the note on 5:2b. This is the same simile here. Jesus will return when most people do not expect him.

1 Thessalonians 5:5

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and

those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 5:4–11

Because the Lord will return suddenly but people do not know when this will happen, Paul told the believers at Thessalonica that they should be prepared for the Lord Jesus to return at any time.

5:5a

For you are all sons of the light and sons of the day;

- I say this because you all are people who belong to the light and belong to the day.
- I say this because you all are people who behave well and do what is right, which is like living in the light and belonging to the day.

For: The Greek conjunction *gar*, which the BSB translates as *For*, indicates that the words that follow are the grounds or evidence for Paul’s words in 5:4a. Here is one way to translate this:

It will not come unexpectedly for you because
(SSA)

Many English versions leave this conjunction implicit in this verse. Introduce this verse in a natural way in your language.

you are all sons of the light and sons of the day:

To refer to someone as the “son” of some object is a Hebrew metaphor. It means that the person has the same characteristics as the object or belongs to the object.

sons of the light: This means those who live in the light (as opposed to the darkness in 5:4a, 5:5b), those who belong to the light. You should try to translate this in a way that contrasts with 5:4a.

sons of the day: This means those who belong to the day (as opposed to the night in 5:5b). It may mean the same thing as “sons of the light.”

These are difficult phrases to translate. Here are two suggested ways to deal with this part of the verse:

- You could keep the metaphor of light and day, as most modern English versions have done. For example:

people who belong to the light, who belong to the day (GNT)

- You could combine the two metaphors. For example,

people who do everything as though it were done in the light, that is, in the daytime (UBS Handbook, page 109)

people who do what is right as people usually do when it is light/daytime” (SSA).

5:5b

we do not belong to the night or to the darkness.

- We^(incl) believers are not people who belong to darkness and belong to the night.
- We^(incl) believers are not people who sin and behave in evil ways, which is like living in darkness and belonging to this evil world.

we do not belong to the night or to the darkness:

This part of the verse repeats 5:5a, but it uses negative statements instead of the positive ones of 5:5a. The word darkness here means the same as it does in 5:4a.

we: This refers to all believers.

1 Thessalonians 5:6

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 5:4–11

Because the Lord will return suddenly but people do not know when this will happen, Paul told the believers at Thessalonica that they should be prepared for the Lord Jesus to return at any time.

5:6a

So then, let us not sleep as the others do,

- Therefore, let us^(incl) not be asleep like others who are not aware that Jesus will come back.
- So let us^(incl) not be like unbelievers who are like people who are asleep and unaware of what is going to happen.

So then: This introduces the clause that follows logically from 5:4–5. Paul was telling the Thessalonians that since they were sons of light and the day, they should not behave like unbelievers.

let us not sleep: This time Paul was not using sleep as a euphemism for “death.” Rather, he meant that unbelievers were like people who are sound asleep, unaware of what is happening. He was continuing the

metaphor of a thief coming in the night (5:2b). Unbelievers are like a homeowner who is sleeping when the thief comes; they will not be ready when Jesus returns. However, Paul was warning believers not to be like this. They should be expecting Jesus to return. See also Matthew 25:1–13.

us: This refers to all believers, not just Paul and his companions.

as the others do: Paul was warning all who claimed to be believers to behave as believers should and not like unbelievers who did not believe that Jesus would come again.

5:6b

but let us remain awake and sober.

- Instead, we^(incl) should be alert and control ourselves^(incl),
- On the contrary, we^(incl) should be like those who are awake and ready for Jesus’ return and we^(incl) should be self-controlled.

but let us remain awake: This metaphor is the opposite of the one in 5:6a, so it means “we should be aware” that Jesus will return suddenly, and we should be ready for him. See Matthew 25:13; Mark 13:35–37.

sober: The Greek verb *nēphō* literally means “to be sober” and usually refers to not being drunk. However, in this context, many commentators agree that it does not just refer to avoiding being intoxicated. Rather, its meaning is extended to mean being self-controlled. Here is another way to translate this:

self-controlled (NIV)

1 Thessalonians 5:7

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 5:4–11

Because the Lord will return suddenly but people do not know when this will happen, Paul told the believers at Thessalonica that they should be prepared for the Lord Jesus to return at any time.

5:7a

For those who sleep, sleep at night;

- because it is at night that people sleep and are unaware of what is going to happen,

For: The Greek conjunction *gar*, which the BSB translates as *For*, has a number of functions. Here it indicates that Paul was amplifying what he had just said in 5:6. In many languages it may not be necessary to translate the conjunction here.

those who sleep, sleep at night: Here Paul was stating something that is obviously true: “people usually sleep at night.” He was probably continuing the metaphors of “sleep” and “night” that he had already used in this chapter.

at night: The Greek word *nuktos*, which the BSB translates as *at night*, is emphasized in Greek. Show this emphasis in a natural way in your language. For example:

It is at night when people sleep (GNT)

5:7b

and those who get drunk, get drunk at night.

- and it is at night that people get drunk.

those who get drunk, get drunk at night: Paul was once more stating what people knew to be true, that usually people become drunk and behave badly during the night, after dark. This introduces Paul’s next point in 5:8, that since Christians “belong to the day,” they should be self-controlled and not behave like unbelievers.

at night: As in 5:7a, the Greek word *nuktos*, which the BSB translates as *at night*, is emphasized in Greek. Show this emphasis in a natural way in your language. For example:

it is at night when they get drunk (GNT)

1 Thessalonians 5:8

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 5:4–11

Because the Lord will return suddenly but people do not know when this will happen, Paul told the believ-

ers at Thessalonica that they should be prepared for the Lord Jesus to return at any time.

5:8a

But since we belong to the day, let us be sober,

- But since we^(incl) belong to the day, we^(incl) should control ourselves.^(incl)
- But since we^(incl) are people who do what is right, we^(incl) should be self-controlled.

we belong to the day: Paul had already reminded the Thessalonians that they were “sons of the day.” See the note on 5:5a.

let us be sober: See the note on 5:6b. This is the same word in Greek and should be translated in the same way.

5:8b–c

In the rest of the verse, Paul introduced a new metaphor, that of a soldier and his armor. He was probably thinking about Isaiah 59:17. See also Ephesians 6:11–18. Paul meant that Christians use their faith, love, and hope to protect themselves when the devil attacks them. Paul had already mentioned that the Thessalonians had these qualities in 1 Thessalonians 1:3.

5:8b

putting on the breastplate of faith and love,

- Let our^(incl) faith in Jesus and our^(incl) love for other people protect us^(incl) like a breastplate protects a soldier.
- Let us^(incl) continue to believe in Jesus and love other people. That will protect us^(incl) like a breastplate protects a soldier.
- As a soldier protects himself by putting on a breastplate, we^(incl) must protect ourselves^(incl) from the devil’s attacks by continuing to trust in Jesus and continuing to love other people.

putting on: This verb is connected with “let us be sober” in 5:8a. It explains how they should control themselves. Here is another way to translate this:

by putting on (NET)

breastplate: This is the piece of armor a soldier wears to protect the front of his body.

faith: In this context, this refers to believing in Jesus Christ. If a Christian stops believing in Jesus, he becomes weak and the devil can attack him easily by tempting him to do wrong.

love: In this verse Paul probably intended this to refer to the Thessalonians’ love for other people, rather

than their love for God. This is the view of most commentators.

5:8c

and the helmet of our hope of salvation.

- And let our^(incl) certain hope that Jesus will save us^(incl) protect us^(incl) like a helmet protects a soldier.
- As a soldier protects himself by putting on a helmet, we^(incl) must protect ourselves^(incl) from Satan by confidently expecting that Jesus will save us.^(incl)
- And let us^(incl) be certain that Jesus will save us.^(incl) That will protect us^(incl) like a helmet protects a soldier.

the helmet of our hope of salvation: See the notes on hope in 1:3d and 4:13b. Believers do not just vaguely hope that they will be saved someday. They confidently expect that when Jesus returns, he will save them rather than punish them as he will punish unbelievers. They also expect that he will take them to be with him forever. Firmly knowing these things protects believers against the devil when he attacks.

helmet: This is the hat that a soldier wears to protect his head.

If you need to make a lot of implied information explicit in your translation, you could translate 5:8b–c as follows:

We must continue to believe in Jesus, continue to love others, and believe firmly that Jesus will save us in order that we may protect ourselves when the devil attacks us, just as a soldier puts on a breastplate and helmet to protect himself when the enemy attacks.

1 Thessalonians 5:9

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 5:4–11

Because the Lord will return suddenly but people do not know when this will happen, Paul told the believers at Thessalonica that they should be prepared for the Lord Jesus to return at any time.

5:9a

For God has not appointed us to suffer wrath,

- All this is because God did not choose us^(incl) so that he might judge us^(incl) to be guilty and punish us.
- For God did not choose us^(incl) in order to condemn us^(incl) as people whom he will punish.

For: Here Paul wrote another reason for his commands in 5:6–8: Because God did not appoint Christians to suffer wrath, they must be alert and self-controlled.

appointed: Paul meant that God deliberately chose (or destined) to save those who have trusted in Jesus, rather than to punish them as he will punish unbelievers.

to suffer wrath: This refers to God's anger. This is the usual phrase to express that God is angry with those who refuse to repent and trust in him and that God will punish them when the Lord Jesus returns.

5:9b

but to obtain salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ.

- On the contrary, he destined us^(incl) to be saved from being punished by means of what our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ has done for us^(incl).

but to obtain salvation: In this context, salvation probably refers to when Jesus returns to judge everyone. At that time believers will be saved rather than being punished.

through our Lord Jesus Christ: It is God who saves people, but he does so by means of what Jesus has done through his death on the cross. This is made clear by the link to 5:10a. You may need to add this implied information in your translation.

1 Thessalonians 5:10

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 5:4–11

Because the Lord will return suddenly but people do not know when this will happen, Paul told the believers at Thessalonica that they should be prepared for the Lord Jesus to return at any time.

5:10a

He died for us

- Jesus died for us^(incl)
- Jesus died on our^(incl) behalf

He died for us: In the Greek text this phrase is closely connected to 5:9b. It explains more clearly the phrase “through our Lord Jesus Christ.”

for us: Paul said that Jesus died in order to benefit believers in some way. In this case, 5:10b–c gives the benefit: “so that...we may live together with Him.”

5:10b

so that, whether we are awake or asleep,

- in order that, whether we^(incl) are still alive or have died when he returns,

so that: This translates a conjunction that indicates one of the purposes for which Jesus died (5:10a), that is, that all believers will be able to live with Jesus forever.

whether we are awake: In this context, being awake refers not to “being alert” (5:6b) but to being alive at the time when Jesus comes again.

or asleep: Paul was once more using sleep as a euphemism for “death,” as he did in 4:13a, 4:14b, and 4:15c.

5:10c

we may live together with Him.

- we^(incl) will go and live together with him.

we may live together with Him: Commentators do not agree about which word together should be connected with. There are two possible interpretations:

1. It is connected with the phrase with Him and means that believers will live in heaven together with Christ. This seems to be what all English versions follow.
2. It is connected with the verb live and means “together with each other.” That is, the two groups of believers, those who are still alive when Jesus returns and those who have already died but whom God will resurrect, will together go and be with Jesus.

The first option is the most natural way to understand the Greek grammatical construction here. So it is recommended that you follow it (1).

Paul does not say where the believers will live with Jesus. The important point is that wherever Jesus is, on earth or in heaven, the believers will be with him.

1 Thessalonians 5:11

Section 4:13–5:11: Paul taught about when the Lord Jesus would return

Paul explained that when the Lord Jesus returns, God will cause both the Christians who have died and

those who will still be alive to ascend to meet the Lord Jesus in the sky. He also explained how the Thessalonians should behave as they waited for the Lord to return.

Paragraph 5:4–11

Because the Lord will return suddenly but people do not know when this will happen, Paul told the believers at Thessalonica that they should be prepared for the Lord Jesus to return at any time.

5:11a

Therefore encourage and build one another up,

- Therefore since that is true, continually encourage and help one another to believe more strongly in Jesus,

Therefore: This word introduces the conclusion of Paul’s words in 5:1–10.

encourage...one another: This is identical to the phrase in 4:18, which was the concluding sentence of 4:13–18. See the note on 4:18. You should translate it in the same way here.

build one another up: The Greek word oikodomeō means “to build a house.” However, here it is used as a metaphor and it means “strengthen one another,” that is, “help one another to believe more strongly in God.”

5:11b

just as you are already doing.

- just as in fact you are encouraging and helping one another.

just as you are already doing: Paul recognized that the Thessalonians were already encouraging one another and building each other up, but he wanted to encourage them to continue doing so.

1 Thessalonians 5:12

Section 5:12–22: Paul gave more instructions about how to please God

In this section Paul gave a list of some very important instructions. He returned to the topic he had started in 4:12, the topic of how Christians should behave.

Paragraph 5:12–13

The first instruction Paul gave was that the Thessalonians were to respect and honor their church leaders.

5:12a

But we ask you, brothers, to acknowledge those who work diligently among you,

- ¶ Brothers, we^(excl) urge you to respect those who work hard/diligently among you

- ¶ Moving on to another matter, brothers, we^(excl) ask you to appreciate/esteem your leaders who work hard/diligently in your midst,

But: The BSB has used the word But to signal a new unit in the text, in this case, a new section. You should not translate it literally but use the appropriate method your language uses to signal a new section. This may be a special grammatical form, a specific word, or maybe nothing at all.

brothers: See the note on 1:4.

to acknowledge: The Greek verb oida, which the BSB translates as acknowledge, literally means “to know,” but it has a wide range of other meanings. In this context it means “to respect, esteem, appreciate.”

those who work diligently among you: Paul told the Thessalonians that they should respect their leaders not just because of their status as leaders but because of the way they worked to benefit all the believers in Thessalonica. Paul did not specify in this part of the verse what sort of work he was referring to. He was probably using a general expression here that he explained more fully in 5:12b–c.

It is important to notice that here and in 5:12b–c Paul used three expressions to describe the same group of people, the leaders of the believers in Thessalonica. He was not talking about three different groups. Make sure your translation makes this clear.

5:12b

who preside over you in the Lord

- as leaders in the fellowship/community of the Lord Jesus,
- directing/guiding/leading you in your Christian community,

who preside over you: The Greek verb proistēmi, which the BSB translates by the expression preside over, is often used to talk about leaders and the work they do. It can be translated as the BSB has done. Other possibilities are:

who direct/guide you

who are your leaders

in the Lord: Scholars do not agree about what this phrase means here. There are two main possibilities:

1. It means leaders “in spiritual matters.” For example:

in the Lord’s fellowship (REB)

in the Christian life (GNT)

1. It means that it was the Lord who had authorized the leaders.

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1), as it is supported by most commentators.

5:12c

and give you instruction.

- warning you not to sin.

give you instruction: The Greek word noutheteō, which the BSB translates as give...instruction, can mean:

1. It means “to admonish, warn.” (NIV, RSV, NET, KJV, NJB, NLT).
2. It means “to advise, instruct.” (BSB, GNT, GW, NCV, NASB, REB, JB).

It is difficult to decide between these two meanings here, as the meaning is usually determined by the context (for example in 5:14a, where it clearly means “warn”), but the context here does not assist the translator. However, the majority of commentators favor the first option because of the wider context, and it is recommended that you also translate this verb as “to admonish, warn.”

1 Thessalonians 5:13

Section 5:12–22: Paul gave more instructions about how to please God

In this section Paul gave a list of some very important instructions. He returned to the topic he had started in 4:12, the topic of how Christians should behave.

Paragraph 5:12–13

The first instruction Paul gave was that the Thessalonians were to respect and honor their church leaders.

5:13a

In love, hold them in highest regard because of their work.

- Because of what they do for you, respect them well and love them very much.

In love: The Thessalonians were not only to respect their leaders, they were also to love them. The word huperekperissou, which the BSB translates as highest, probably applies to this part of verse, as well as to hold them in...regard. Here, it would mean “love them greatly/exceedingly.”

hold them in highest regard: “To hold someone in regard” is another way in English of saying “to respect/esteem someone.” The verb is not the same

in Greek as the one used in 5:12a, but the meaning is similar. Paul added the adverb *huperekperissou*, which the BSB translates as highest, in order to strengthen the verb. The Thessalonians were not only to respect their leaders, they were to respect them “greatly/exceedingly.”

because of their work: Paul stated that the Thessalonian believers must respect and love their leaders, not because of their status, but because of what they were doing for the rest of the Thessalonian believers.

5:13b

Live in peace with one another.

- Behave peacefully with one another.
- Do not quarrel with one another.

Live in peace with one another: Unlike the previous commands, this one was addressed to all the Christians in Thessalonica, including the leaders. But there is no need to make this explicit in your translation. Paul knew that the devil likes to cause believers to quarrel and so disrupt the fellowship that they have with one another. Paul gave similar commands in other letters too. For example, see 2 Corinthians 13:11.

1 Thessalonians 5:14

Section 5:12–22: Paul gave more instructions about how to please God

In this section Paul gave a list of some very important instructions. He returned to the topic he had started in 4:12, the topic of how Christians should behave.

Paragraph 5:14–18

In these verses Paul gave further commands about how believers should behave.

5:14a

And we urge you, brothers, to admonish the unruly,

- ¶ We^(excl) also urge you, brothers, to warn those who are lazy.
- ¶ We^(excl) also urge you, brothers, to warn those believers who are refusing to work that they must work.

brothers: See the note on 1:4.

admonish: The word admonish is the same word that was translated as “give...instruction” in 5:12c. Here it clearly means “admonish, warn” rather than “advise.”

the unruly: The commentators do not agree about whom this refers to. The word *ataktos*, which the BSB translates as unruly, usually means “disorderly.” So commentators suggest two possible meanings here:

1. It refers to a specific form of disorderliness, that of being idle. Paul was therefore referring to a group of Thessalonian believers who had stopped working (see 1 Thessalonians 4:11–12) because they thought that Christ would return very soon. (NIV, GNT, RSV, NCV, NLT, JB, REB)
2. The word should be understood literally to refer to those who were unruly or disorderly, that is, they refused to obey or respect their leaders. (BSB, KJV, NJB, NASB, CEV, NET, GW)

The commentators are evenly divided between these two views. However, it is clear from 2 Thessalonians 3:6–12 that the first option was a real problem among the believers at Thessalonica. Therefore it is recommended that you follow the first option (1).

5:14b

encourage the fainthearted,

- Encourage those believers who are timid/fearful,

encourage the fainthearted: Paul did not say what had caused some believers at Thessalonica to become fainthearted or “timid.” The commentators suggest that some were fearful because people were persecuting them or because they were worried about fellow believers who had died before Christ had returned. There may also have been some who doubted that Christ had really saved them or felt that they had no spiritual gifts. However, you should not try to include these possibilities in your translation.

5:14c

help the weak,

- help those who are weak in any way,

help the weak: Commentators agree that Paul was not referring to those whose bodies were literally weak because they were sick or old, though he may have been including them. Rather, he was referring either to those who were weak spiritually or to those who were weak morally. There is nothing in the context that can clarify which group he meant. All English versions translate this phrase literally and it is recommended that you either follow them or include a phrase such as “in any way” to make it clear Paul that was not just talking about physical weakness.

5:14d

and be patient with everyone.

- and behave with patience towards every person.

be patient with everyone: Scholars do not agree about whom Paul was referring to here. There are three possibilities:

1. All believers.

2. All people, believers and non-believers alike.
3. The idle, the timid, and the weak of 5:14a-c.

Most English versions do not make it clear which of these possibilities they support. If you decide that you wish to follow one interpretation explicitly, it is recommended that you follow the first option (1).

1 Thessalonians 5:15

Section 5:12–22: Paul gave more instructions about how to please God

In this section Paul gave a list of some very important instructions. He returned to the topic he had started in 4:12, the topic of how Christians should behave.

Paragraph 5:14–18

In these verses Paul gave further commands about how believers should behave.

5:15a

Make sure that no one repays evil for evil.

- Make sure that none of you retaliates if someone else wrongs him.
- If/When someone wrongs one of you, make sure that the wronged person does not retaliate in some way against the person who wronged him.

Make sure that no one repays evil for evil: Paul was telling the Thessalonian believers that they should make sure that no one among them retaliated if someone, whether a fellow believer or an unbeliever, wronged him. Notice that it is not just a command to the person who has been wronged but to the whole Christian community. Christians have responsibility to make sure their fellow believers obey commands such as this.

5:15b

Always pursue what is good for one another and for all people.

- But/Instead, always try hard/earnestly to treat other believers and everyone else kindly.

Always pursue what is good for one another and for all people: Here Paul balanced the negative command in 5:15a with a positive command. It is not enough just to avoid harming others. Paul commanded them to do what is good for both believers and unbelievers.

Always: Paul emphasized the Greek word *pantote* (Always) by placing it at the beginning of the sentence. You should emphasize this in your translation in the way that is natural in your language.

pursue: The BSB translates the Greek verb *diōkō* literally as pursue. Therefore the meaning here is “to try earnestly/strongly, to make a great effort.”

General Comment on 5:16–22

From this point onward, through to 5:22, Paul emphasized certain words in each command by putting that word at the start of the command. These are mentioned as they occur in the notes that follow.

1 Thessalonians 5:16

Section 5:12–22: Paul gave more instructions about how to please God

In this section Paul gave a list of some very important instructions. He returned to the topic he had started in 4:12, the topic of how Christians should behave.

Paragraph 5:14–18

In these verses Paul gave further commands about how believers should behave.

5:16

Rejoice at all times.

- Always be glad.
- Rejoice at all times.
- Be cheerful, no matter what is happening.

Rejoice at all times: The command to Rejoice was especially necessary because the Thessalonians were being persecuted and they could easily have become discouraged and unhappy. Paul commanded them to be full of joy, no matter what happened. See also Philippians 4:4.

at all times: This is the word emphasized in this sentence. See the note on 5:15b above. You should emphasize this in your translation in the way that is natural in your language.

1 Thessalonians 5:17

Section 5:12–22: Paul gave more instructions about how to please God

In this section Paul gave a list of some very important instructions. He returned to the topic he had started in 4:12, the topic of how Christians should behave.

Paragraph 5:14–18

In these verses Paul gave further commands about how believers should behave.

5:17

Pray without ceasing.

- Keep praying.
- At all times be ready to pray to God.

Pray without ceasing: This does not mean that believers should pray many times a day or that they should do nothing but pray. Rather it means that believers should “keep on praying, be always ready to pray”

instead of just doing so at set times or on special occasions.

without ceasing: The Greek word *adialeiptōs*, which means without ceasing or “continually,” is the word emphasized in this sentence. See the note on 5:15b above. You should emphasize this in your translation in the way that is natural in your language.

1 Thessalonians 5:18

Section 5:12–22: Paul gave more instructions about how to please God

In this section Paul gave a list of some very important instructions. He returned to the topic he had started in 4:12, the topic of how Christians should behave.

Paragraph 5:14–18

In these verses Paul gave further commands about how believers should behave.

5:18a

Give thanks in every circumstance,

- Whatever happens to you, whether good or bad, be thankful to God.

Give thanks in every circumstance: Paul instructed the Thessalonians that whether good things or bad things should happen to them, they should still thank God. He did not say what they should thank God for, and you should not try to explain this in your translation.

in every circumstance: The emphasis in this command is on the Greek phrase *en panti*, literally “in every thing.” See the note on 5:15b above. You should emphasize this in your translation in the way that is natural in your language.

5:18b

for this is God’s will for you in Christ Jesus.

- For all these things are what, through Christ Jesus, God wants you to do.
- I am telling you to do these things because all these things are what God wants you to do through Christ Jesus.

for: Paul now gives the grounds for the previous three commands: Since it is God’s will that they should do so, the Thessalonians should be joyful, pray, and give thanks.

this: The majority of commentators say that this refers to the previous three commands: 5:16, 5:17, and 5:18a.

in Christ Jesus: It is not clear which part of the verse this phrase is connected to. There are two possibilities:

1. It is connected to “God’s will.” Most commentators support this interpretation, but they do not agree on what it means here. One possibility is that what Christ taught and how he behaved shows Christians that they should obey all the commands in 5:16–18a.
2. It is connected to “you” and therefore means that these things are what God wants them, people who belong to Christ Jesus, to do. (GNT, NLT)

It is most likely that the first option is grammatically correct, but it is still not easy to decide what the meaning is. If possible, you should avoid being too specific in your translation. However, if it is necessary to make information explicit here, you could translate 5:18b as follows:

because all these things are what God has shown you (plur) that he wants you to do through the way Christ Jesus behaved when he was on earth.

1 Thessalonians 5:19

Section 5:12–22: Paul gave more instructions about how to please God

In this section Paul gave a list of some very important instructions. He returned to the topic he had started in 4:12, the topic of how Christians should behave.

Paragraph 5:19–22

This paragraph deals with Paul’s instructions about how the Thessalonians should treat prophetic messages.

5:19

Do not extinguish the Spirit.

- ¶ Do not extinguish the Holy Spirit’s fire.
- ¶ Do not stop God’s Spirit from working among you.

Do not extinguish the Spirit: Here Paul was using a figure of speech that compared the Holy Spirit to a fire. This same figure of speech occurs elsewhere in the New Testament, for example, Matthew 3:11; Acts 2:3. Some translations include the implied information, “fire,” in order to make the figure of speech clearer. There are different ways you can translate this figure of speech:

- If you have used the metaphor of “fire” for the Holy Spirit elsewhere in the New Testament, you will probably be able to retain it here, though it may be a good idea to make it explicit. For example:

Do not put out the Spirit’s fire (NIV)

- Omit the comparison to “fire” and translate the meaning in a different way. For example:

Do not restrain the Holy Spirit (GNT)

Do not hold back the work of the Spirit (NCV)

You should choose whichever possibility works best in your language.

the Spirit: The phrase the Spirit refers to the Holy Spirit, and you may need to make this explicit in your translation by either using your term for “Holy Spirit” or by using a phrase such as “God’s Spirit.”

The emphasis in this command is on this phrase “the Spirit.” See the note on 5:15b above. You should emphasize this in your translation in the way that is natural in your language.

1 Thessalonians 5:20

Section 5:12–22: Paul gave more instructions about how to please God

In this section Paul gave a list of some very important instructions. He returned to the topic he had started in 4:12, the topic of how Christians should behave.

Paragraph 5:19–22

This paragraph deals with Paul’s instructions about how the Thessalonians should treat prophetic messages.

5:20

Do not treat prophecies with contempt,

- In particular, do not scorn/despise prophetic messages that other believers speak.
- Specifically, do not disdain/reject what other believers say when the Holy Spirit reveals something to them.

Do not treat prophecies with contempt: Here Paul gave a specific example of how people quench the Holy Spirit’s fire, that is, by rejecting prophecies without first evaluating them.

prophecies: Paul was not referring to Old Testament prophecies in this verse. Rather he was referring to prophecies that fellow believers were making. A prophecy could be about what would happen in the future or about present-day matters. For example, the prophecy could be a warning that God would punish those who were sinning unless they repented. Or it could be a promise that God would forgive, comfort, and encourage those who trusted him.

The emphasis in this command is on this word prophecies. See the note on 5:15b above. You should emphasize this in your translation in the way that is natural in your language.

1 Thessalonians 5:21

Section 5:12–22: Paul gave more instructions about how to please God

In this section Paul gave a list of some very important instructions. He returned to the topic he had started in 4:12, the topic of how Christians should behave.

Paragraph 5:19–22

This paragraph deals with Paul’s instructions about how the Thessalonians should treat prophetic messages.

5:21a

but test all things.

- Instead, evaluate all messages that people claim the Holy Spirit revealed to them.
- But instead listen carefully to and discern all that is said in order to know whether or not the Holy Spirit truly revealed it.

but test all things: Commentators do not agree about what Paul was telling the Thessalonians to test. There are three possibilities:

1. He was telling them to test the prophetic messages he mentioned in 5:20. He was therefore saying that rather than treating prophecies with contempt, they should test them and check to see whether or not the message was from God. A number of English versions have made this connection clear by starting this verse with “but” (BSB, RSV, REB, NLT, NCV) or a similar word such as “instead” (GW). The punctuation of some other English versions suggests that they too support this interpretation (NIV, GNT, NJB).
2. Paul was telling them to test all gifts of the Holy Spirit.
3. Paul was telling them to test everything that affected what believers think and do.

In the context, it seems to make more sense to consider that in 5:21–22 Paul was still discussing prophecies. Therefore it is recommended that you follow the first interpretation.

all things: The emphasis in this command is on this word all things. See the note on 5:15b above. You should emphasize this in your translation in the way that is natural in your language.

5:21b

Hold fast to what is good.

- If the words are true, accept them.
- Accept the authentic messages and obey them.

Hold fast to what is good: Paul continued to tell the Thessalonians how they should treat prophetic

messages. Once they had tested the prophecies, they should accept and obey those that were good, that is, those which came from God.

what is good: The emphasis in this command is on the phrase what is good. See the note on 5:15b above. You should emphasize this in your translation in the way that is natural in your language.

1 Thessalonians 5:22

Section 5:12–22: Paul gave more instructions about how to please God

In this section Paul gave a list of some very important instructions. He returned to the topic he had started in 4:12, the topic of how Christians should behave.

Paragraph 5:19–22

This paragraph deals with Paul's instructions about how the Thessalonians should treat prophetic messages.

5:22

Abstain from every form of evil.

- If the messages are evil in any way, reject them.
- Do not obey any kind of evil message.

Abstain from every form of evil: As this verse is in contrast to 5:21b, it too probably refers to prophecies rather than general evil. So Paul was concluding his instructions on how to deal with prophecies. The Thessalonians were not to despise them, but test them, and then accept those that came from God and reject those that were evil, that is, those that did not come from God.

every form of evil: The emphasis in this command is on this phrase every form of evil. See the note on 5:15a above. You should emphasize this in your translation in the way that is natural in your language.

1 Thessalonians 5:23

Section 5:23–28: Paul prayed that God would bless the Thessalonians

Paragraph 5:23–24

To conclude his letter, Paul prayed that God would make the Thessalonian believers completely pure in all that they believed and did. He assured them that God would enable them to do this.

5:23a

Now may the God of peace Himself

- ¶ I pray to God, who gives peace to his people,

Now: The BSB has used the English word Now as an idiomatic way of beginning this verse. Be careful not

to translate this literally as a time word, as it is not referring to “the present time.”

the God of peace: This phrase means that God is the source of peace, that is, that God is the one who causes people to be peaceful.

peace: The New Testament speaks about different sorts of peace, for example:

1. Peace between individuals.
2. Peace between God and people.
3. An inward calm.

However, most commentators agree here that Paul was using the Greek word *eirēnē* as he would have used the Hebrew word *šalom*. He therefore meant all the blessings, physical and spiritual, that God gives to his people. See the note on 1:1d.

Paul used this phrase in other letters; see Romans 15:33, 16:20; Philippians 4:9. It is also used in Hebrews 13:20. You should translate the phrase in the same way in each of these verses.

Himself: The Greek word *autos*, Himself, is often used to emphasize something. However, that is not true in this verse. It is just a usual opening for a prayer in Greek that asks God to do something for someone.

5:23b

sanctify you completely,

- that he will make you completely pure.
- that he will cause you to be completely pleasing to him.

sanctify: This word means “to make holy/pure.” See the note on “holy” in 3:13b and 4:3a. See also sanctify meaning 1 in the glossary. Paul explained more fully what he meant in 5:23c.

completely: This means that Paul wanted God to sanctify the Thessalonians in every part of their lives.

5:23c

and may your entire spirit, soul, and body be kept blameless at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ.

- That is, I pray that he will prevent your whole spirit and soul and body from sinning in any way until the day when our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ comes again.
- That is, I pray that he will cause every part of you to be completely acceptable to him until our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ comes again.

and may your entire spirit, soul, and body be kept blameless at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ:

Some commentators suggest that this sentence is the desired result of 5:23b. It is more likely, however, that Paul was expanding what he had said in 5:23b.

He wanted the believers at Thessalonica to behave in a righteous manner so that when Christ returned, he would not be able to criticize or accuse them because of anything they had done. However, Paul knew that only God could help them behave like that.

spirit, soul, and body: This is the only place in the New Testament where such a distinction is made. Paul probably used all three to emphasize that a person is a whole being, rather than because he intended to distinguish the three terms. If your language does not make a similar three-way distinction, it may be helpful to distinguish at least between the body and the part of a person that continues to live after the body dies. The important thing in your translation is to show that everything Christians do must be pleasing to God.

blameless at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ: Paul was praying that God would enable them to be blameless from the present time until the Lord Jesus returned, so that when Jesus returned, he would judge them as having done nothing for which they deserved to be punished. See the notes on 3:13b and 3:13c.

1 Thessalonians 5:24

Section 5:23–28: Paul prayed that God would bless the Thessalonians

Paragraph 5:23–24

To conclude his letter, Paul prayed that God would make the Thessalonian believers completely pure in all that they believed and did. He assured them that God would enable them to do this.

5:24

The One who calls you is faithful, and He will do it.

- Since God calls you to be holy, he will enable you to do that, because he always does what he says he will do.
- God never fails to do what he has promised. Therefore, since he calls you to be holy, he will enable you to be holy.

The One: This refers to God. You may need to make this explicit in your translation to make the meaning clear.

who calls you is faithful, and He will do it: God is faithful and trustworthy because he always does what he has promised to do. In this context, this refers to the fact that God has promised to sanctify believers and that the Thessalonians can trust him to do what he promised.

1 Thessalonians 5:25

Section 5:23–28: Paul prayed that God would bless the Thessalonians

5:25

Brothers, pray for us as well.

- ¶ Brothers, also pray for us.^(excl)

Brothers: See the note on 1:4.

pray for us as well: There is a minor textual problem with this verse.

1. Some Greek manuscripts contain a Greek word that may be translated as well or “also.” These manuscripts are followed by the (BSB, GNT, NET, REB)
2. Most other English versions omit this word. If the word is included, the verse means: “We prayed for you, and now you should also pray for us.” (Paul’s prayer for the Thessalonians was in 5:23.) This is the option followed by the Display.

us: This refers to Paul and his companions.

1 Thessalonians 5:26

Section 5:23–28: Paul prayed that God would bless the Thessalonians

5:26

Greet all the brothers with a holy kiss.

- Greet all the brothers and sisters affectionately.
- Greet all the believers by embracing them.

brothers: See the note on 1:4.

with a holy kiss: At the time Paul was writing this letter, a kiss was one way people would greet one another to show love or respect. Men kissed other men, and women kissed other women. This was particularly true within families. So it was appropriate for believers to greet one another by kissing them, as members of God’s family. Paul probably used the adjective holy to distinguish this greeting from the sort of kissing that might take place between a man and a woman. It is not clear from the text or from what we know about the culture at that time which part of the body they kissed. If believers kissing one another is not acceptable in your culture or if you have no term for kissing, translate the expression in a more general way, for example, “greet the brothers affectionately.” This expression is also used in Romans 16:16; 1 Corinthians 16:20; 2 Corinthians 13:12. 1 Peter 5:14 contains the expression “a kiss of love.”

1 Thessalonians 5:27

Section 5:23–28: Paul prayed that God would bless the Thessalonians

5:27

I charge you before the Lord to have this letter read to all the brothers.

- I order/command you in the name of the Lord Jesus to read this letter to all your brothers.
- I ask you to promise me in the name of the Lord Jesus that you will read this letter to the rest of the brothers.

I charge you: The verb *enorkizō*, which the BSB has translated as *charge*, is a verb used for making people take an oath or make a solemn promise to do something. Another way to translate it would be: “I ask you to solemnly promise...” Paul was ordering the Thessalonians to do something, not asking them to do it.

before the Lord: There are two possible interpretations of this expression in this context:

1. It was a standard expression for making an oath. See Mark 5:7, which contains a similar construction. This would mean that Paul was saying: “I ask you to promise me in the name of the Lord Jesus that you will...” This would then make the Thessalonians accountable to the Lord Jesus. (BSB, NIV, RSV, NET, REB, NASB, KJV)
2. It means that it was the Lord who authorized Paul to give this command. (GNT, NJB, GW, CEV, NCV, NLT)

Either of these is possible, but as the phrase is used in the context of an oath, it is recommended that you follow the first option (1).

the Lord: This probably refers to Jesus here.

to have this letter read to all the brothers: Paul was concerned that not just the people who received the letter read it, but that all the believers would hear the contents. What Paul taught was for all the believers in Thessalonica.

brothers: See the note on 1:4.

1 Thessalonians 5:28

Section 5:23–28: Paul prayed that God would bless the Thessalonians

5:28

The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you.

- ¶ We^(excl) pray that our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ will bountifully/greatly bless you.

The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you: Paul ended all his letters with a form of blessing. The form varies from letter to letter. For grace, see the note on 1:1d.

Several English versions include the word “Amen” at the end of the letter. This word is found in some ancient manuscripts. However, it is recommended that you not include this word in your translation, as it is not found in the manuscripts that scholars consider most reliable.